



CONTINGENCY LESSONS

Reading for SylvanSync™

Advanced



GRADES 9-12

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Story Summary 1

Objectives

The student will be able to:

- write a summary of a fictional passage.
- create flash cards for unfamiliar vocabulary words.
- study the new vocabulary words.

Materials

- index cards
- markers
- writing paper

Background Information

When you **summarize**, you use your own words to briefly retell the main ideas, events, or details from a story you have read. A summary contains only the most important details, so it is much shorter than the original.

Pausing to summarize as you read helps you check your comprehension before you read further. While reading the original story, take note of the questions: who, what, when, where, why, and how. Using these questions to examine what you are reading will help you to write the summary.

Summarizing is an effective strategy for reading any type of genre. Writing a summary will help you understand and remember what you have read.

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Story Summary 1

Use these steps and guidelines to help you compose a summary.

1. Read the passage. Read with who, what, when, where, why, and how questions in mind.
2. Reread the passage and underline significant ideas. Circle key terms. Find the main idea.
3. Write a sentence that states the main idea of the passage. This is first thing to include in the summary.
4. You might want to use this format to guide you in writing a summary. In "title of the passage," "author" shows that "central idea of the passage." The author supports the main idea by using _____ and showing that _____.
5. Write your rough draft and include the central ideas, key words, important data, and any important conclusions. Keep your summary short. Do not rephrase the original passage. Use your own wording. Do not put in your opinion of the issue or topic discussed in the original passage.
6. Edit your summary. Be concise. Eliminate inessential words and repetitions.

This lesson is based on a genre of writing that comes from a writer's imagination. **Fiction** is prose writing that creates stories that tell about people, places, ideas, or events that are made up by the author. Examples of this genre are: novels, myths, fairy tales, and short stories. Some authors rely on their imaginations alone to create their fictional writing pieces. Others base their fictional stories on actual events and people, to which they add invented characters, dialogue, and plot situations.

Complete the activities that follow on a separate sheet of paper.

Answer the following questions about the elements of a summary and nonfiction writing.

1. A summary will include only the main ideas and pertinent details of the original passage.
 - a. true
 - b. false
2. A summary should contain the title and the author of the passage.
 - a. true
 - b. false
3. The main idea of the original passage should be included only at the very end of the summary.
 - a. true
 - b. false
4. A fictional passage will always include authentic events and people.
 - a. true
 - b. false

Read the following paragraph and explain why it is a summary. Write your response on your writing paper.

During the war in 1781, a very courageous girl saved her baby sister from a group of robbers that broke into her family's home. While the robbers were pillaging her home, the girl and her parents concealed themselves in the upstairs bedroom. Her parents soon realized that the girl's baby sister was asleep downstairs. The girl heroically sneaked past the robbers to save her baby sister.

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Story Summary 1

Part 3

Read the adapted short story “The Californian’s Tale” by Mark Twain. While you are reading, take notes on the main or important ideas, important details or events, and unfamiliar vocabulary words.

The Californian's Tale

Thirty-five years ago I was prospecting on the Stanislaus. It was once populous, but now people had vanished, and now it was a solitude. They went away when the surface diggings gave out. In the neighborhood one found cozy cottages, so cobwebbed with vines that the doors and windows were hidden—sign that these were deserted. One also came across solitary log cabins, built by the first gold-miners. If these were occupied, the occupant was the pioneer who had built the cabin.

It was a lonesome land! Not a sound in those expanses; no glimpse of man or beast. One afternoon, I caught sight of a human. The man was about 45. He was standing by one of those cottages. This one hadn't a deserted look; it had the look of being cared for. I was invited in—it was the custom. It was delightful, after weeks of miners' cabins—with dirt floors, tin plates, beans, and black coffee. Here was a nest which had aspects to rest the tired eye.

"All my darling wife's work," he said, "she did it all herself." He took me into a bedroom so that I might wash my hands; such a bedroom: pillows, carpet, pictures, a mirror, and in the corner a china bowl, pitcher, and soap, and on a rack—towels too clean and white for one out of practice to use.

"All her work; she did it all herself. That's her picture. Nineteen her last birthday," he said, "and that was the day we were married."

"Where is she? When will she be in?"

"Oh, she's away. Gone to see her people who live 40 miles from here. She's been gone two weeks."

"When do you expect her back?"

"She'll be back Saturday, in the evening—about nine o'clock."

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That night we talked about things, but mainly about her. Thursday followed and slipped comfortably away. A miner from three miles away came—one of the grizzled pioneers, "I only dropped over to ask about the little madam."

"Oh, yes, I have a letter from her. Would you like to hear it, Tom?"

"I should think I would, if you don't mind, Henry!" Henry got the letter, and read—a loving, charming, gracious piece, with a postscript of affectionate regards to all. "Well, I must be going. I'll be on hand when she comes!"

Friday afternoon another veteran tramped over from his cabin a mile away, and said the boys wanted to have a little gaiety Saturday night, if Henry thought she wouldn't be too tired after her journey. "YOU know she'd sit up six weeks to please any one of you!"

Saturday afternoon I found I was taking out my watch often. Henry noticed, and said, "You don't think she ought to be here?" I felt embarrassed and said it was a habit when I was in a state of expectancy. "I'm getting worried. I know she's not due till nine."

I was glad when Charley, another veteran, arrived, and talked over preparations. Charley did his best to drive away his friend's apprehensions. "Anything HAPPENED to her? Henry, that's pure nonsense. There isn't anything going to happen. She'll BE here."

Tom and Joe arrived, and set about adorning the house with flowers. It was getting close to nine. Henry was standing in the door with his eyes directed up the road. Henry shouted, "Boys, I'm sick with fear. Help me—I want to lie down!" They helped him to the sofa. He began to drowse, but spoke like one talking in his sleep, "Did I hear horses? Have they come?" One of the veterans answered, "It was Jimmy Parish saying her horse is lame."

"Oh, I'm SO thankful nothing has happened!" He was asleep. The men tucked him into bed. They seemed preparing to leave; but I said, "Please don't go. She won't know me."

They glanced at each other. Then Joe said, "She's been dead 19 years!"

"Dead?"

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"She went to see her folks half a year after she was married, and she's never been heard of since."

"And he lost his mind in consequence?"

"Never has been sane since. He only gets bad when this time of year comes. We begin to drop in three days before, to ask if he's heard from her, and Saturday we come and fix up the house with flowers. We've done it every year for 19 years. He's all right for another year—thinks she's with him till the last three days; then he begins to look for her, and gets out his poor old letter, and we come and ask him to read it to us. Lord, she was a darling!"

This selection is not copyrighted in the U.S.

Now answer these questions.

1. What is the main idea of this passage?
 - a. It is important to remember the ones you loved.
 - b. Surface gold mining is difficult and not very profitable.
 - c. Friends are those that listen to you and know how to help.
 - d. A person can become very saddened by the loss of someone.
2. How do you know that this passage is fictional?
 - a. The passage includes imagined details and people.
 - b. The passage establishes clearly the author's point of view.
 - c. The passage persuades the reader to take a certain action.
 - d. The passage provides the reader with real events and ideas.
3. Why did most of the cottages look deserted?
 - a. The cottages appeared to have been occupied by miners.
 - b. The cottages appeared to be in disrepair and falling down.
 - c. The cottages were empty and the doors and windows were open.
 - d. The cottages were densely covered with vines that were entwined.

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Story Summary 1

4. What will the narrator probably do next year at this same time if he is prospecting on the Stanislaus?
 - a. He will ask if he can stay at Henry's cottage.
 - b. He will investigate the woman's disappearance.
 - c. He will participate in the imaginary homecoming event.
 - d. He will take time to play music with the grizzled miners.
5. What is the meaning of the word tramped as it is used in this sentence from the story?

Friday afternoon another veteran tramped over from his cabin a mile away, and said the boys wanted to have a little gaiety Saturday night, if Henry thought she wouldn't be too tired after her journey.

- a. to dance lightly
- b. to walk heavily
- c. to wander aimlessly
- d. to stamp repeatedly

Part 4

1. Using the index cards, create flash cards for any unfamiliar vocabulary that you identified in the short passage in Part 3. Write the unfamiliar word on one side and the definition on the other side.
2. Now create a crossword puzzle on your writing paper to help you practice these vocabulary words.

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Grades 9–12
Story Summary 1

Part 5

Write a summary of the fictional passage you read in Part 3 on your writing paper. Make sure that your response includes the elements of a summary. Your writing will be evaluated using the following 3-point rubric.

Writing Rubric

Score	Addresses the Topic	Supports the Summary Appropriately	Uses Correct Grammar, Capitalization, Punctuation, and Spelling
3	Targets the writing exactly to the topic. Does not shift focus.	Uses all characteristics of a summary.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout the summary.
2	Does a good job staying on topic. May wander or shift focus slightly.	Uses a few characteristics of a summary.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout some of the summary.
1	Does not address the topic at all.	Does not use appropriate characteristics of a summary.	There is no attempt at correct capitalization, punctuation, and spelling in the summary.

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Story Summary 2

Objectives

The student will be able to:

- write a summary of a fictional story.
- create flash cards for unfamiliar vocabulary words.
- study the new vocabulary words.

Materials

- index cards
- markers
- writing paper

Background Information

When you **summarize**, you use your own words to briefly retell the main ideas, events, or details from a story you have read. A summary contains only the most important details, so it is much shorter than the original.

Pausing to summarize as you read helps you check your comprehension before you read further. While reading the original story, take note of the questions: who, what, when, where, why, and how. Using these questions to examine what you are reading will help you to write the summary.

Summarizing is an effective strategy for reading any type of genre. Writing a summary will help you understand and remember what you have read.

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Story Summary 2

Use these steps and guidelines to help you compose a summary.

1. Read the passage. Read with who, what, when, where, why, and how questions in mind.
2. Reread the passage and underline significant ideas. Circle key terms. Find the main idea.
3. Write a sentence that states the main idea of the passage. This is the contained in the first sentence of the summary.
4. You might want to use this format to guide you in writing a summary. In "title of the passage," "author" shows that "central idea of the passage." The author supports the main idea by using _____ and showing that _____.
5. Write your rough draft and include the central ideas, key words, important data, and any important conclusions. Keep your summary short. Do not rephrase the original passage. Use your own wording. Do not put in your opinion of the issue or topic discussed in the original passage.
6. Edit your summary. Be concise. Eliminate inessential words and repetitions.

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Complete the activities that follow on a separate sheet of paper.

Answer the following questions about the elements of a summary and nonfiction writing.

1. A summary will include only the main ideas and pertinent details of the original passage.
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During the war in 1781, a very courageous girl saved her baby sister from a group of robbers that broke into her family's home. While the robbers were pillaging her home, the girl and her parents concealed themselves in the upstairs bedroom. Her parents soon realized that the girl's baby sister was asleep downstairs. The girl heroically sneaked past the robbers to save her baby sister.

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Story Summary 2

Part 3

Read the adapted short story “The Child’s Story” by Charles Dickens. While you are reading, take notes on the main or important ideas, important details or events, and unfamiliar vocabulary words.

The Child's Story

Once there was a traveler who set out on a journey. He traveled along a path, without meeting anything, until he came to a beautiful child. He said to the child, “What do you do here?” The child said, “I am always at play. Come and play with me!” So, he played.

The sky was blue, the sun was bright, the water was sparkling, the leaves were green, the flowers were lovely, and they heard birds, and everything was beautiful. They had plenty of the finest toys, and the astonishing picture-books. But the traveler lost the child. He called to him, but got no answer.

So, he went upon his road, and went on for a while without meeting anything, until he came to a handsome boy. He asked, “What do you do here?” And the boy said, “I am always learning. Come and learn with me.” So he learned about Jupiter, Juno, Greeks, Romans, and learned more. They were not always learning; they had the merriest games that ever were played. They had holidays, and theatres where they saw palaces of gold and silver. They had dear friends. Still, one day, in the midst of all this, the traveler lost the boy as he had lost the child, and, after calling to him in vain, went on upon his journey.

So he went on for a while without seeing anything, until he came to a young man. He said to the young man, “What do you do here?” The young man said, “I am always in love. Come and love with me.” So, he went with that young man, and they came to one of the nicest girls that ever were. The young man fell in love. The traveler lost the young man one day, as he had lost the rest of his friends, and, after calling to them went on upon his journey.

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So, he went on for a while without seeing anything, until at last he came to a middle-aged man. He said, "What are you doing?" His answer was, "I am always busy. Come and be busy with me!" So, he began to be busy with that man, and they went on through the wood together. The man was not alone, but had his wife; and they had children. They all went on through the wood, cutting down trees, and making a path, working hard.

Sometimes, they came to a green avenue that opened into deeper woods. They would hear a distant voice crying, "Father, I am another child! Stop for me!" And presently they would see a little figure, growing larger as it came along, running to join them. When it came up, they all crowded round, and kissed and welcomed it; and then they all went on together. Sometimes, they came to several avenues at once, and they stood still, and one of the children said, "Father, I am going to sea," and another, "Father, I am going to India," and another, "Father, I am going to seek my fortune." So, with tears, they went, solitary, down those avenues. During these partings, the traveler looked at the man, and saw that his hair was turning gray. But, they never could rest long, for it was necessary to be always busy. At last, there had been so many partings that there were no children, and only the traveler, the man, and the wife, went upon their way in company.

Now the wood was yellow and brown, and the leaves, even of the forest trees, began to fall. They came to an avenue that was darker than the rest, and were pressing forward on their journey without looking down it when the wife stopped. "My husband," said the wife. "I am called." They listened, and they heard a voice down the avenue, say, "Mother!" Then, the mother, who was already drawn into the shade of the dark avenue and moving away with her arms still round his neck, kissed him, and said, "My dearest, I am summoned, and I go!" And she was gone. And the traveler and he were left alone together. They went on together, until they came to very near the end of the wood: so near, that they could see the sunset shining red before them through the trees. Yet, once more, while he broke his way among the branches, the traveler lost his friend.

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Story Summary 2

He called, but there was no reply, and when he passed out of the wood, and saw the peaceful sun going down upon a wide purple prospect, he came to an old man sitting on a fallen tree. So, he said to the old man, "What do you do here?" The old man said with a calm smile, "I am always remembering. Come and remember with me!" So the traveler sat down by the old man; and all his friends came softly back and stood around him. The beautiful child, the handsome boy, the young man in love, the father, mother, and children. So, he loved them all, and was kind and forbearing with them all, and was always pleased to watch them all, and they all honored and loved him. And I think the traveler must be yourself, dear Grandfather, because this is what you do to us, and what we do to you. This selection is not copyrighted in the U.S.

Now answer these questions.

1. What is the main idea of this passage?
 - a. While traveling, you can have new experiences.
 - b. The phases of life are experienced differently by each person.
 - c. Traveling can be lonely unless you are prepared to meet others.
 - d. It is important to enjoy each phase of life and the people you encounter.
2. How do you know that this passage is fictional?
 - a. The passage includes imaginary details and people.
 - b. The passage provides the reader with events and ideas.
 - c. The passage establishes clearly the author's point of view.
 - d. The passage persuades the reader to take a certain action.
3. How many different males did the traveler meet on his journey?
 - a. 3
 - b. 4
 - c. 5
 - d. 6

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Grades 9–12
Story Summary 2

4. How do you think the narrator will travel on his own journey of life?
 - a. He will take more time to play with his children and continue to work.
 - b. He will be a better person than the other people he met on his journey.
 - c. He will be patient, gentle, with his family members just like his grandfather.
 - d. He will work hard and let his own children go out on their own adventures.
5. What is the meaning of the idiom in vain as it is used in the second paragraph?
 - a. excessively proud
 - b. foolish
 - c. irreverent
 - d. without effect

Part 4

3. Using the index cards, create flash cards for any unfamiliar vocabulary that you identified in the short story in Part 3. Write the unfamiliar word on one side and the definition on the other side.
4. Now create a word search on your writing paper to help you practice these vocabulary words.

Reading for SylvanSync™
Grades 9–12
Story Summary 2

Part 5

Write a summary of the fictional passage you read in Part 3 on your writing paper. Make sure that your response includes the elements of a summary. Your writing will be evaluated using the following 3-point rubric.

Writing Rubric

Score	Addresses the Topic	Supports the Summary Appropriately	Uses Correct Grammar, Capitalization, Punctuation, and Spelling
3	Targets the writing exactly to the topic. Does not shift focus.	Uses all characteristics of a summary.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout the summary.
2	Does a good job staying on topic. May wander or shift focus slightly.	Uses a few characteristics of a summary.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout some of the summary.
1	Does not address the topic at all.	Does not use appropriate characteristics of a summary.	There is no attempt at correct capitalization, punctuation, and spelling in the summary.

Reading for SylvanSync™
Grades 9–12
Nonfiction Article Summary 1 (Social Studies)

Objectives

The student will be able to:

- write a summary of a nonfiction article.
- create flash cards for any unfamiliar vocabulary.
- study the new vocabulary words.

Materials

- index cards
- markers
- writing paper

Background Information

When you **summarize**, you use your own words to briefly retell the main ideas, events, or details from a story you have read. A summary contains only the most important details, so it is much shorter than the original.

Pausing to summarize as you read helps you check your comprehension before you read further. While reading the original story, take note of the questions: who, what, when, where, why, and how. Using these questions to examine what you are reading will help you to write the summary.

Summarizing is an effective strategy for reading any type of genre. Writing a summary will help you understand and remember what you have read.

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Nonfiction Article Summary 1 (Social Studies)

Use these steps and tips to help you write a summary.

1. Read the story. Read with who, what, when, where, why, and how questions in mind.
2. Reread the story and underline important ideas. Circle key terms. Find the main idea.
3. Write a sentence that states the main idea of the story. This is the first thing to include in the summary.
4. You might want to use this format to help you. In "title of the story," "author" shows that "central idea of the story." The author supports the main idea by using _____ and showing that _____.
5. Write your rough draft and include the important ideas, key words, important data, and any important conclusions. Keep your summary short. Do not rewrite the original story. Use your own wording. Do not put in your opinion of the issue or topic discussed in the original story.
6. Edit your summary. Be concise. Eliminate needless words and repetitions.

This lesson is based on a genre that is informative and factual. **Nonfiction** is prose writing that presents and explains ideas or that tells about real people, places, ideas, or events. To be classified as nonfiction, a work must be true. Examples of this genre are: newspaper stories, editorials, journals, and textbooks.

Complete the activities that follow on a separate sheet of paper.

Answer the following questions about the elements of a summary and nonfiction writing.

- ## Part 2

Read the following summary and explain why it is a summary, and what has been omitted. Write your response on your writing paper.

Overall, the changes that have occurred in hockey have facilitated the advancement of the sport. Hockey is faster and more electrifying as a result of modifications to the rules and the equipment in the past 120 years. Furthermore, the players are more physically fit, more adept, and more athletic. For these reasons, contemporary hockey is a better sport than hockey in the 1890s.

Reading for SylvanSync™
Grades 9–12
Nonfiction Article Summary 1 (Social Studies)

Part 3

Read the article “Legend of the Alps.” While you are reading, take notes on the main or important ideas, details or facts, and unfamiliar vocabulary words.

Legend of the Alps

The Saint Bernard Monastery, established approximately in the 1050s, was located in a pass (later called the Saint Bernard Pass) through the Swiss Alps. It served as a hospice for trekkers and pilgrims. The hospice offered the sojourners three days of lodging and meals before they continued on their excursion through the snow-covered mountains. The first Saint Bernard dogs arrived at the hospice between 1660 and 1670 to be used as watchdogs. The monks discerned that the dogs' size and strength made them ideal for other responsibilities. Soon the dogs were turning a wheel that rotated a cooking spit over a fire. Later, they escorted monks traveling through the Alps and aided them in navigating up and down the frozen footpaths.

By 1750, Saint Bernards were being utilized by mountain guides. Their ability to clear paths through the snow and to navigate through blinding snowstorms and thick fog, combined with their astonishing sense of direction, made them extremely adept at their occupation. When they first began to be utilized for rescues is unclear. However, it is known that Saint Bernards were on duty when Napoleon and his army of a quarter of a million soldiers traversed the Alps in 1800, and not a single soldier succumbed to the freezing conditions of the mountains. The last documented rescue by a Saint Bernard was that of a twelve-year-old boy in 1827.

Although the picture of a Saint Bernard with a barrel around its neck is a common representation of the noble canine, there is no documentation among the writings of the monks at the hospice that such a vessel was ever used. Other stories, such as the rescue of a small boy by a dog who carried him on its back, also seem to be more legend than actuality. However, it is truth, not legend, that Saint Bernards saved more than two thousand lives in the two hundred years that they were active in the Alps. This fact alone makes these large, hardworking dogs worthy of a legend or two.

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Nonfiction Article Summary 1 (Social Studies)

Now answer these questions.

1. What is the main idea of this article?
 - a. personal accounts and opinions of the Saint Bernard
 - b. information about the characteristics of the Saint Bernard
 - c. history of the changes in the utilization of the Saint Bernard
 - d. legends, stories, and facts of the success of the Saint Bernard
2. How do you know that this article is nonfiction?
 - a. The article provides a humorous story.
 - b. The article includes factual information.
 - c. The article outlines the main characteristics of the breed.
 - d. The article establishes a supported point of view.
3. Who were the first people to employ the Saint Bernard?
 - a. guides
 - b. monks
 - c. pilgrims
 - d. trekkers
4. What is the author's opinion of the breed of Saint Bernard?
 - a. Legends of the breed are frivolous and disrespectful.
 - b. Training of the breed is both problematic and lengthy.
 - c. The breed should be only permitted to live in the alps.
 - d. The size and tenacity of the breed allows it to be legendary.

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Nonfiction Article Summary 1 (Social Studies)

5. What is the meaning of the word sojourners as it is used in the first paragraph?
- a. canines
 - b. inhabitants
 - c. travelers
 - d. vagabonds

Reading for SylvanSync™
Grades 9–12
Nonfiction Article Summary 1 (Social Studies)

Part 4

1. Using the index cards, create flash cards for any unfamiliar vocabulary that you identified in the article in Part 3. Write the unfamiliar word on one card and the definition on a second index card.
2. Lay the flash cards face down on the table. Then turn one card up to read the word or the definition. Turn another card up to read the word or the definition. If they match, put them aside. If they don't match return them to the table, face down. Continue until you have matched up all of the cards.

Reading for SylvanSync™
Grades 9–12
Nonfiction Article Summary 1 (Social Studies)

Part 5

Write a summary of the nonfiction passage you read in Part 3 on your writing paper. Make sure that your response includes the elements of a summary. Your writing will be evaluated using the following 3-point rubric.

Writing Rubric

Score	Addresses the Topic	Supports the Summary Appropriately	Uses Correct Grammar, Capitalization, Punctuation, and Spelling
3	Targets the writing exactly to the topic. Does not shift focus.	Uses all characteristics of a summary.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout the summary.
2	Does a good job staying on topic. May wander or shift focus slightly.	Uses a few characteristics of a summary.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout some of the summary.
1	Does not address the topic at all.	Does not use appropriate characteristics of a summary.	There is no attempt at correct capitalization, punctuation, and spelling in the summary.

Reading for SylvanSync™
Grades 9–12
Nonfiction Article Summary 2 (Science)

Objectives

The student will be able to:

- write a summary of a nonfiction article.
- create flash cards for any unfamiliar vocabulary.
- study the new vocabulary words.

Materials

- index cards (or blank paper)
- markers
- writing paper

Background Information

When you **summarize**, you use your own words to concisely reiterate the main ideas, events, or details from an article you have read. A summary includes only the most important details, so it is much shorter than the original. However, you do not omit every detail. A summary must contain enough detail to ensure that the main idea or events are clear.

Pausing to summarize as you read can benefit your comprehension as you read. While reading the original article, take note of the questions: who, what, when, where, why, and how. Using these questions to examine what you are reading will support you in writing the summary. Summarizing is an effective strategy for reading any genre of text. Writing a summary will help you understand and remember what you have read.

For example, what might you include in a summary of a science report on a specific animal? To summarize the report, you would tell about the animal's habitat, life cycle, and food preferences. You would probably describe a few of the animal's primary characteristics, but you would not try to retell every characteristic. Your summary would be an abbreviated retelling in your own words.

At the same time, a summary must include enough information to be useful to the reader. What if you said, "The animal is small and likes to eat plants and lives in the woods"? The summary might be perfectly accurate, but it's too short to be worthwhile to the reader because it includes too little information. Summaries should be helpful both to you as the reader of a passage and to the person who reads your summary.

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Grades 9–12

Nonfiction Article Summary 2 (Science)

Use these steps and guidelines to help you compose a summary.

1. Read the article. Read with who, what, when, where, why, and how questions in mind.
2. Reread the article and underline significant ideas. Circle key terms. Find the main idea.
3. Write a sentence that states the main idea of the article. This is the contained in the first sentence of the summary.
4. You might want to use this format to guide you in writing a summary. In "title of the article," "author" shows that "central idea of the article." The author supports the main idea by explaining that _____ and showing that _____.
5. Write your rough draft and include the central ideas, key words, important data, and any important conclusions. Keep your summary short. Do not rephrase the original article. Use your own wording. Do not put in your opinion of the issue or topic discussed in the original article.
6. Edit your summary. Be concise. Eliminate inessential words and repetition of ideas.

This lesson is centered on a genre that is characteristically both informative and factual. **Nonfiction** is prose writing that presents and clarifies ideas or that articulates details about real people, locales, concepts, or happenings. To be classified as nonfiction, a work must be factual. Examples of this genre are: newspaper stories, editorials, journals, and textbooks.

Reading for SylvanSync™
Grades 9–12
Nonfiction Article Summary 2 (Science)

Activity

Complete the activities that follow on a separate sheet of paper.

Part 1

Answer the following questions about the elements of a summary and nonfiction writing.

1. A summary will include all details presented in the original article.
a. true b. false
2. A summary is written to concisely reiterate the essential concepts of an article.
a. true b. false
3. The title and author should be included in a summary of a nonfiction article.
a. true b. false
4. The main idea of the original article should be included at the very end of the summary.
a. true b. false
5. A nonfiction article will include true, accurate concepts.
a. true b. false

Part 2

Read the following paragraph and explain why it is a summary. Write your response on your writing paper.

The article “Protecting Wyoming’s Wolves” by Darryn Green discusses how the Wyoming Wildlife Rescue Association is studying wolves in the Seedskaadee National Wildlife Refuge. Using data they have gathered on the possible extinction of wolves in the area, the WWRA makes the case for giving the area permanent protection. That means restricting road access, logging, and the use of motorized vehicles in the wolves’ habitat. The Wyoming Wildlife Rescue Association members are pushing to increase the wolf population in the area so as to diversify the types of animals in the habitat, which will permit the food chain to flourish.

Reading for SylvanSync™
Grades 9–12
Nonfiction Article Summary 2 (Science)

Part 3

Read the article “Elephants.” As you read, create three lists: 1) the main or important ideas, 2) the details or facts, and 3) the unfamiliar vocabulary words.

Elephants

Elephants are enormous yet graceful animals. Adult elephants usually weigh around 6,000 pounds. Even with such bulky, hefty bodies, elephants walk unobtrusively at a pace of about four miles per hour and can run at a pace of about 25 miles per hour.

Elephants are noted for their tusks made of treasured ivory. Elephant tusks are actually two, lengthy, upper incisors that typically weigh 50 to 100 pounds each. These tusks are used to root for food and water, to strip bark off trees, and to fight. Inside the mouth, elephants have four molars. Each weighs approximately 11 pounds. Remarkably, the front pair of molars wears down from chewing, the back pair shift forward, and a new pair grows to supplant the back pair. This cycle occurs six times in an elephant's life. The last pair of molars falls out when the elephant is between 40 to 60 years old. Without molars, the elephant is incapable of masticating well enough to eat; therefore, it dies of starvation. This is a very common cause of death for elephants.

Another characteristic associated with elephants is the trunk. Actually, the trunk is a combination of an elephant's nose and upper lip. There are approximately 150,000 muscles in this flexible appendage. The trunk is very versatile and can be used similarly to the way humans use their hands. For example, elephants can grasp low-lying bushes, higher tree branches, and other vegetation and convey these plants to their mouths using their trunks. Elephants use their trunks to drink, too, as they suck up water and squirt it into their mouths. They even use their trunks to spray water over themselves to bathe. They also use their trunks as snorkels when they are under water to allow them to breathe.

Elephants eat between 165 to 330 pounds of food each day; in fact, they must spend approximately three-quarters of every day feeding! Elephants in the wild eat from as many as 80 diverse plant species, but elephants in captivity have a more structured diet. Captive elephants feast on grain, hay, carrots, apples, cabbage, and other fruits and vegetables.

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Grades 9–12
Nonfiction Article Summary 2 (Science)

Elephants live in tightly knit matriarchal families led by the oldest females. Each family is comprised of mothers, aunts, sisters, nieces, cousins, and young males. Family members stay close together and travel as a group. If one family member wanders off for too long, the remaining elephants welcome him or her back by spinning in circles, clicking tusks, and rubbing up against each other. Mature males live alone or form male family groupings.

Elephants exhibit complex emotional behaviors. For example, when an elephant is born, family members celebrate and help in the rearing of the calf. On the other hand, when a family member dies, elephants have been known to shed tears. Elephants in captivity often create relationships with certain caretakers and trainers and will not cooperate with other workers.

Elephants are acknowledged as being one of the most intelligent species of mammals. Although intelligence is difficult to measure, in general, elephants are very playful and can learn to perform tricks quite effortlessly and quickly. For example, many elephants are used in circuses to perform tricks. Also, young elephants have been seen playing tag, tug of war, and hide and seek!

Over the past 40 million years, there were more than 600 elephant species roaming Earth. Now, only two species remain: the African and the Asian. Unfortunately, these remaining two species are now endangered. In fact, in the 1900s there were between 5 and 10 million wild elephants. Now, there are only 600,000 African elephants remaining in the wild. Since elephants do not have enemies in the wild, ivory poachers have been the main cause of their destruction.

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Grades 9–12
Nonfiction Article Summary 2 (Science)

Now answer these questions.

1. What is the main idea of this article?
 - a. Zoologists are studying how to communicate with elephants.
 - b. The life cycle of an elephant allows it to grow to its enormous size.
 - c. Worldwide regulations must be enforced to ensure the future of elephants.
 - d. Elephants' characteristics are fascinating but put them at risk of extinction.
2. How do you know that this article is nonfiction?
 - a. The article provides a humorous story.
 - b. The article includes factual information.
 - c. The article outlines all the rules of the sport.
 - d. The article establishes a supported point of view.
3. What percentage of a day does an elephant in the wild forage for food?
 - a. 5%
 - b. 15%
 - c. 25%
 - d. 75%
4. What is a possible prediction of what will happen to elephants in the wild?
 - a. The Asian elephants will be trapped and moved to zoos.
 - b. The ivory of the African elephants will no longer be desired.
 - c. The population of elephants in the wild will continue to decline.
 - d. Elephants in the wild will roam to areas unavailable to poachers.

Reading for SylvanSync™
Grades 9–12
Nonfiction Article Summary 2 (Science)

5. What is the meaning of the word masticating as it is used in the second paragraph?
- a. blending
 - b. chewing
 - c. digesting
 - d. mixing

Part 4

1. Using the index cards, create flash cards for any unfamiliar vocabulary that you identified in the article in Part 3. Write the unfamiliar word on one card and the definition on a second index card.
2. Lay the flash cards in a row with the definitions face up on the table. Take the cards with the words and match them by putting the word card on top of the correct definition until you have matched all the cards. Now reverse the cards. Lay the flash cards with the words face up and match with the definitions.

Reading for SylvanSync™
Grades 9–12
Nonfiction Article Summary 2 (Science)

Part 5

Write a summary of the nonfiction passage you read in Part 3 on your writing paper. Make sure that your response includes the elements of a summary. Your writing will be evaluated using the following 3-point rubric.

Writing Rubric

Score	Addresses the Topic	Supports the Summary Appropriately	Uses Correct Grammar, Capitalization, Punctuation, and Spelling
3	Targets the writing exactly to the topic. Does not shift focus.	Uses all characteristics of a summary.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout the summary.
2	Does a good job staying on topic. May wander or shift focus slightly.	Uses a few characteristics of a summary.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout some of the summary.
1	Does not address the topic at all.	Does not use appropriate characteristics of a summary.	There is no attempt at correct capitalization, punctuation, and spelling in the summary.

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Drama

Objectives

The student will be able to:

- describe the features and functions of the elements of a play.
- read a play part "in character," using expressive oral reading.
- write an additional scene for a play.

Materials

- writing paper
- pen or pencil

Background Information

A **play** is a story written with the intention of being performed by actors on a stage. The story is written as a **script**. The author, or playwright, uses dialogue spoken by the characters to advance the plot. The **playwright** or **dramatist** provides instructions about how a play should be performed through **stage directions**. These are instructions to the performers or descriptions to the reader that are separated from the **dialogue** by parentheses or brackets.

Like other prose, plays have **characters** who take part in the action of the story. The main characters face a **conflict**, or struggle, that moves the sequence of events called the **plot**.

The ancient Greeks developed plays or dramas into two basic categories. These categories are still used today to categorize plays. The first is a **tragedy**, which deals with the downfall of the main character. The other is a **comedy**, which is a play with a happy ending. The primary difference between a tragedy and a comedy is the ending.

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Drama

Use this chart to help you better understand the features and functions of a play.

Features and Function of a Play

Features	Functions
Acts	The primary organization of a play. A play may have one or more acts.
Scenes	An act is divided into one or more scenes. A scene moves the action to a new setting or time of day, or introduces a new character.
Stage Directions	Instructions about how a play should be performed. Usually set in italics and/or set off by brackets. These include background information about the setting or characters.
Character	Person being played by an actor or actress in the play.
Dialogue	Conversation; the spoken words between two or more characters.
Monologue	A long speech delivered by one character.
Soliloquy	A character's speech to him or herself, showing the character's thoughts and motivations.
Aside	A quick remark, often humorous, by a character to the audience rather than to the other characters.

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Drama

Activity

Complete the activities that follow on a separate sheet of paper.

Part 1

Read this adapted excerpt from Act One, Scene One of the play *The Importance of Being Earnest* by Oscar Wilde.

The Importance of Being Earnest

Cast

John Worthing, *J.P.*
 Algernon Moncrieff
 Lane, *Manservant*
 Lady Bracknell
 Hon. Gwendolen Fairfax

Algernon Moncrieff's Flat in Half-Moon Street, W.

Morning-room in Algernon's flat in Half-Moon Street. The room is luxuriously and artistically furnished. The sound of a piano is heard in the adjoining room.

(Lane is arranging afternoon tea on the table, and after the music has ceased, Algernon enters.)

Algernon: Did you hear what I was playing, Lane?

Lane: I didn't think it polite to listen, sir.

Algernon: I'm sorry for that, for your sake. I don't play accurately—any one can play accurately—but I play with wonderful expression.

Lane: Yes, sir.

Algernon: Have you got the cucumber sandwiches cut for Lady Bracknell?

Lane: Yes, sir. *(Hands them on a tray.)*

Algernon: *(Inspects them, takes two, and sits down on the sofa.)* Oh! . . . by the way, Lane, I see from your book that on Thursday night, when Lord Shoreman and Mr. Worthing were dining with me, eight bottles of champagne are entered as having been consumed.

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Grades 9–12
Drama

Lane: Yes, sir; eight bottles and a pint.

Algernon: Why is it that at a bachelor's establishment the servants invariably drink the champagne?

Lane: I attribute it to the superior quality of the wine, sir. I have often observed that in married households the champagne is rarely of a first-rate brand.

Algernon: Good heavens! Is marriage so demoralizing as that?

Lane: I believe it is a very pleasant state, sir. I have only been married once.

Algernon: (*Languidly.*) I don't know that I am much interested in your family life, Lane.

Lane: No, sir; it is not a very interesting subject. I never think of it myself.

Algernon: Very natural, I am sure. That will do, Lane, thank you.

Lane: Thank you, sir. (*Lane goes out.*)

Algernon: Lane's views on marriage seem somewhat odd. Really, if the lower orders don't set us a good example, what on earth is the use of them?

(*Enter Lane.*)

Lane: Mr. Ernest Worthing.

(*Enter Jack and Lane goes out.*)

Algernon: How are you, my dear Ernest? What brings you up to town?

Jack: Oh, pleasure! What else should bring one anywhere? Eating as usual!

Algernon: (*Stiffly.*) I believe it is customary in good society to take some slight refreshment at five o'clock. Where have you been since Thursday?

Jack: (*Sitting down on the sofa.*) In the country.

Algernon: What on earth do you do there?

Jack: (*Pulling off his gloves.*) When one is in town one amuses oneself. When one is in the country one amuses other people.

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Drama

Algernon: And who are the people you amuse?

Jack: (*Airily.*) Oh, neighbours.

Algernon: Got nice neighbours?

Jack: Perfectly horrid! Never speak to one of them.

Algernon: How immensely you must amuse them! (*Goes over and takes a sandwich.*)

Jack: Why all these cups? Why cucumber sandwiches? Why such reckless extravagance in one so young? Who is coming to tea?

Algernon: Oh! merely Aunt Augusta and Gwendolen.

Jack: How perfectly delightful!

Algernon: I am afraid Aunt Augusta won't quite approve of your being here.

Jack: May I ask why?

Algernon: My dear fellow, the way you flirt with Gwendolen is perfectly disgraceful. It is almost as bad as the way Gwendolen flirts with you.

Jack: I am in love with Gwendolen. I have come up to town to propose.

Algernon: I thought you had come up for pleasure? . . . I call that business.

Jack: How utterly unromantic you are!

(*Silence.*)

Jack: (*Noticing that Algernon is holding his silver case.*) Have you had my case all this time?

Algernon: (*Opens the case and examines it.*) No, this isn't yours at all. The inscription inside says "To my dear Uncle Jack." Please explain. Your name isn't Jack at all; it is Ernest.

Jack: It isn't Ernest; it's Jack.

Algernon: You have always told me your name was Ernest. I have introduced you to every one as Ernest. You answer to the name of Ernest. You look as if your name was Ernest. You are the most earnest-looking

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Drama

person I ever saw in my life. It is perfectly absurd your saying that your name isn't Ernest. It's on your cards. Here is one of them. (*Taking it from case.*) 'Mr. Ernest Worthing.' I'll keep this as a proof that your name is Ernest if ever you attempt to deny it to me or anyone else. (*Puts the card in his pocket.*)

Jack: Well, my name is Ernest in town and Jack in the country.

(*The sound of an electric bell is heard.*)

Algernon: Ah! that must be Aunt Augusta. Only relatives, or creditors, ever ring in that Wagnerian manner. Now, if I get her out of the way for ten minutes, so that you can have an opportunity for proposing to Gwendolen, may I dine with you to-night at Willis's?

Jack: I suppose so, if you want to.

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Identify the following features in the play. Then on your paper, write the name of the feature and the example you identified.

- Stage directions
- Character
- Dialogue
- Setting
- Conflict

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Grades 9–12

Drama

Part 2

Based on Act One, Scene One in the play *The Importance of Being Earnest*, answer the following questions.

1. What do the stage directions in this line tell you about the character?

Algernon: (*Stiffly.*) I believe it is customary in good society to take some slight refreshment at five o'clock. Where have you been since Thursday?

2. Why does the playwright include this information at the beginning of the scene?

Morning-room in Algernon's flat in Half-Moon Street. The room is luxuriously and artistically furnished.

3. Why does the playwright include the list of names at the beginning of the scene?
4. Why does the playwright write the separate lines for each character throughout the scene?
5. What is the purpose of conflict in a play?

Part 3

Answer the following questions based on Act One, Scene One of *The Importance of Being Earnest*.

1. Why do you think that all of the Algernon speaks a bit rudely to Lane?
2. What would you probably see on the stage in this scene?
3. What could be added to the stage directions at the end of the scene to better help the reader understand the play?
4. Write an aside that could be added to Lane's second line in the play.

Lane: Yes, sir.

5. What do you predict could happen in Scene Two of this play?

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Drama

Part 4

Practice reading to yourself Scene Two of *The Importance of Being Earnest*. Think about how each of the characters would sound and look reading their lines. Be prepared to be "in character" by using expressive oral reading of this scene.

Part 5

Now it is your turn to be a playwright. Write Scene Two for Act One of *The Importance of Being Earnest*. Make sure that you include the appropriate elements of a play. Your writing will be evaluated using the following 3-point rubric. Write your scene on your paper.

Writing Rubric

Score	Addresses the Structure of the Scene	Use Features of a Play Appropriately	Uses Correct Grammar, Capitalization, Punctuation, and Spelling
3	Targets the structure of the scene exactly.	Uses many of the appropriate features of a play in the scene.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout the scene.
2	Does a good job of targeting the structure of the scene but wanders a bit.	Uses a few appropriate features of a play.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout some of the scene.
1	Does not address the structure of the scene at all.	Does not use appropriate features of a play.	There is no attempt at correct capitalization, punctuation, and spelling in the scene.

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Op-Ed Essay

Objectives

The student will be able to:

- distinguish facts from opinions.
- analyze the author's argument.
- write an opinion piece for a local newspaper.

Materials

- writing paper

Background Information

The ability to read, view, and listen critically are important skills that you will use throughout your life. You deal with **fact** and **opinion** every day, but you probably do not consciously categorize a statement as a fact or an opinion. To be a critical thinker you need to be able to analyze and interpret information intelligently. To be a wise consumer, you must be able to judge whether the information in text, advertisements, or other media is factual, or merely the opinion of an individual or entity.

Facts are statements that can be substantiated as true. A fact exists independent of your personal experiences and knowledge. You can verify a fact using reputable sources. Always be aware that a fact can be misapplied and manipulated when it is taken out of context or in combination with other irrelevant facts.

Opinions are statements that may sound thoughtful, but they cannot be demonstrated as true or false; additionally, these statements can be debated by others. Opinions are subjective interpretations. Just like facts, opinions can be manipulated and taken out of context. An opinion is a personal thought, feeling, or viewpoint that cannot be confirmed.

Statements of fact and opinion are sometimes written together in one piece of writing. The editorial section of a newspaper is an example of writing that is opinion, but may also contain fact.

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Op-Ed Essay

Let's say you want to start a new exercise program. You look online for programs located close to your home. You decide to join a bicycling group because you believe it will be a fantastic way to lose weight and meet new people. You decide not to join a running club because you think that running might damage your knees and you find it a bit boring. What you think about bicycling and running are your opinions. This is your opinion, and someone else who wants to begin exercising might argue with you about bicycling and running. The underlined words indicate that these are your opinions. It would be very hard to prove that you think that running is boring.

The bicycling club posts facts about bicycling, including how many calories the average person burns while biking for an hour, various routes, and group rides. These facts can be researched and verified as to their truth. Being able to differentiate between what is fact and what is opinion will enable you to make informed decisions. Learning to identify indicators, or signal words, will help you discern between fact and opinion.

This chart lists some signal words that can help you to differentiate between facts and opinions.

Fact	Opinion
verified	feel
documented	favorite
research shows	always
statistical data	most
according	should
official	never
studies	believe
citations from experts	think
numbers	perhaps
dates	probably

Reading for SylvanSync™
Grades 9–12
Op-Ed Essay

Activity

Complete the activities that follow on a separate sheet of paper.

Part 1

Fact/opinion sort: Read the following sentences. On a sheet of paper, draw a two-column chart like the one below. Write the number of the sentence in the “Fact” column if the sentence expresses a fact, and write the number of the sentence in the “Opinion” column if the sentence expresses an opinion.

1. All people are afraid of tornadoes.
2. The months of April and May have the most tornadoes.
3. The tornado was categorized as an F2 when it was spotted.
4. People should seek shelter when there is a threat of a tornado.
5. I believe that tornadoes are never as bad as they are reported to be.
6. Winds during the tornado suddenly increased.
7. It would be best if you listened to the television reports.
8. It was an unlucky day for the town.
9. The tornado caused millions of dollars of damage.
10. Storm watchers searched the skies for a funnel cloud.

Fact	Opinion

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Grades 9–12
Op-Ed Essay

Part 2

Think of taking a vacation with friends to go skiing.

What are some facts about a ski vacation? On a sheet of paper, write four facts about a ski vacation.

What is your opinion about a ski vacation? On your paper, write two opinions about a ski vacation.

Part 3

First identify the sentence as a fact or opinion by writing “Fact” or “Opinion” on your paper. Then, if the sentence is an opinion, rewrite it as a fact. If the sentence is a fact, rewrite it as an opinion.

1. It was compulsory to complete the assignment.
2. I believed that the lectures would be fascinating.
3. The lecture series consisted of five different speakers.
4. Each speaker lectured for an hour followed by questions and answers.
5. The speaker was quite articulate and inspiring to the audience.

Reading for SylvanSync™
Grades 9–12
Op-Ed Essay

Part 4

Read the following excerpt from the "State of the Union Address" by President Richard M. Nixon.

Occasionally there comes a time when profound and far-reaching events command a break with tradition. This is such a time.

I say this not only because 1970 marks the beginning of a new decade in which America will celebrate its 200th birthday. I say it because new knowledge and hard experience argue persuasively that both our programs and our institutions in America need to be reformed.

The moment has arrived to harness the vast energies and abundance of this land to the creation of a new American experience, an experience richer and deeper and more truly a reflection of the goodness and grace of the human spirit.

The seventies will be a time of new beginnings, a time of exploring both on the earth and in the heavens, a time of discovery. But the time has also come for emphasis on developing better ways of managing what we have and of completing what man's genius has begun but left unfinished.

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Grades 9–12
Op-Ed Essay

Now, on a sheet of paper, draw a two-column chart like the one below. In this chart, write three opinions and two facts from the passage.

Opinions	Facts

Then, on your paper write one to two sentences that explain whether Nixon sufficiently supports his argument.

Reading for SylvanSync™
Grades 9–12
Op-Ed Essay

Part 5

Write an article for your local newspaper expressing your opinions of the possibility of requiring all students to wear uniforms. Make sure that you support your opinions with facts. Your writing will be evaluated using the following 3-point rubric. Write your article on your paper.

Writing Rubric

Score	Addresses the Topic	Supports the Topic Appropriately	Uses Correct Grammar, Capitalization, Punctuation, and Spelling
3	Targets the writing exactly to the topic. Does not shift focus.	Uses several appropriate facts to support the main topic.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout the writing.
2	Does a good job staying on topic. May wander or shift focus slightly.	Uses a few facts to support the main topic.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout some of the writing.
1	Does not address the topic at all.	Does not use appropriate facts to support the topic.	There is no attempt at correct capitalization, punctuation, and spelling.

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Blog

Objectives

The student will be able to:

- summarize a blog entry.
- evaluate the author's credibility and position.
- write a blog entry.

Materials

- writing paper

Background Information

When you **summarize**, you use your own words to concisely reiterate the main ideas, events, or details from an article you have read. A summary only contains the most important details, so it is much shorter than the original. However, you do not omit every detail. A summary is comprised of sufficient detail to ensure that the main idea or events are clear.

Pausing to summarize as you read can benefit your comprehension of the text. While reading the original article, take note of the questions: who, what, when, where, why, and how. Using these questions to examine what you are reading will support you in writing the summary. Summarizing is an effective strategy for reading any type of genre. Writing a summary will help you understand and remember what you have read.

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Blog

Use these steps and guidelines to help you compose a summary.

1. Read the article. Read with who, what, when, where, why, and how questions in mind.
2. Reread the article and underline significant ideas. Circle key terms. Find the main idea.
3. Write a sentence that states the main idea of the article. This is the contained in the first sentence of the summary.
4. You might want to use this format to guide you in writing a summary. In "title of the article," "author" shows that "central idea of the article." The author supports the main idea by explaining that _____ and showing that _____.
5. Write your rough draft and include the central ideas, key words, important data, and any important conclusions. Keep your summary short. Do not rephrase the original article. Use your own wording. Do not put in your opinion of the issue or topic discussed in the original article.
6. Edit your summary. Be concise. Eliminate unnecessary words and repetitions.

Blogs have become a basic part of the online culture. Practically everyone reads blogs, whether they're "official" news blogs from traditional news media, topic-based blogs related to one's work or hobbies, or blogs purely for entertainment. Just about anyone you ask has at least one favorite blog. Blogs are used by millions of people to write and share anything that comes to mind on a regular basis.

Blogging is the keeping of an online journal or diary. In this journal, a person writes about a subject that they are passionate about or have an interest in. Other people from around the world will then provide feedback responding to your writing on the subject.

Blogs have a relatively short history. It's only in the past five to ten years that they've really taken off. It wasn't until 1997 that the term "weblog" was used. Weblog was then shortened to "blog" sometime around 1999. Five years later Merriam-Webster declared the word their word of the year.

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Blog

These tips and ideas will help you write and maintain your blog.

1. Write often: Try to write at least once a week.
2. Keep notes: When you actually sit down to write, you will have two or three ideas based on your notes.
3. Have a time to write: This is very personal. You might write better in the morning or you might write better in the evening.
4. Contribute to the conversation: It's important to say something new and interesting.
5. Be yourself: Ideally you want to say something interesting. Just be yourself. Some of the best blogs are the ones that are unique and highly personal. There will always be an audience in the blogosphere.
6. Use pictures: Pictures, cartoons, and illustrations are essential.

With the advent of social media and networking in the past five years, blogs have become only one portion of an individual's online personality. Blogs are unlikely to disappear in the future.

Complete the activities that follow on a separate sheet of paper.

Answer the following questions about the elements of a summary and a blog.

1. A summary will include all of the details that are included in the original article.
 - a. true
 - b. false
2. A summary is written to briefly retell the central point of an article.
 - a. true
 - b. false
3. If possible, you should include the title and the author in a summary of a text.
 - a. true
 - b. false
4. The main idea of the original article should be included at the very end of the summary.
 - a. true
 - b. false
5. A blog always includes the writer's name, address, and phone number.
 - a. true
 - b. false

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Blog

Part 2

Read the blog entry “Being a Vegetarian.” While you are reading, take notes on the main or important ideas, details or facts, and unfamiliar vocabulary words.

Being a Vegetarian

On my continuing search for better health I, Donald Harrell, have concluded that we need to eat more vegetables and less meat because vegetables are the foods that do us the most good and our planet the least harm. I know, you might be very keen on meat-eating. But you can eat some meat and still include more veggies—those crunchy, crispy, natural sources of nutrients. Do I need to provide you with numerous arguments to support that assertion? Is there anyone who seriously doubts it to be true?

Just ask yourself if you think anyone is endangering their health by eating too many vegetables. Or if you think the world might be a better, cleaner, greener place with a few more factory chicken farms or intensive pig sties. We just flat out eat too much meat in the western world—too much for our own health and too much for the welfare of the animals. I believe that factory farming is environmentally and ethically wrong. I believe in being a selective omnivore who only consumes ethically produced meat and sustainably caught fish. I now understand that I need to control and limit my appetite for these foods. Over the last 18 months or so, I have undergone a change in the way I cook. Most meals I eat contain no meat or fish. And I can tell you, that I eat better than ever. That's no lie! Why don't I allow a modest amount of meat into meals? Because it would be cheating, that's why! That approach is ultimately the wrong attitude.

As the best vegetarian cooks know, you can produce delicious and balanced meatless meals. We all require protein in our diets (though in fact we don't need a huge amount). I exploit the vital food value and culinary potential of nuts, seeds, grains, beans, walnuts, and quinoa, fresh leafy greens, crunchy roots, and succulent fruits. I have to admit, at first, it was hard to shake off the need for meat. I have actually found it rather liberating. I've found a new pleasure in cooking for myself, family, and friends.

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Grades 9–12

Blog

A lot of dishes can be prepared ahead and actually taste better. Cooking this way does not need to be massively time-consuming. There are all sorts of ways to make it fit into a busy life—from cooking in big batches and freezing them, to buying pre-prepared vegetables. There are plenty of quick and meat-free recipes.

A meal based around several vegetarian dishes needn't require much work. You need only a couple of "prepared" things for a family meal, which you can complement with good bread and a salad of ripe cherry tomatoes or a pile of raw carrots. These dishes can be prepared and consumed from meal to meal. Leftovers from yesterday's supper are often a crucial element of today's lunch. It's a relaxed way of cooking and eating.

Even if I can't tempt you into this way of serving dinner, I hope I can convince you that putting meat and fish aside can lead you into a vast new area of wonderful, wholesome dishes. Vegetable soups alone offer countless opportunities for experimentation—and if that term "vegetable soup" doesn't inspire you, please think again. I'm not talking about thin, tasteless broths but chunky, flavorful bowls: soups like the hearty Italian pasta fagilio, full of beans, garlic, and olive oil.

Undeniably, we are faced with the challenging question: how can we eat well every day without contributing to global warming, the suffering of animals, or the plundering of marine resources? There is only one answer: eat more vegetables! The crucial object is your mental shift. I predict you will find it a breeze.

Now answer these questions.

1. What is the main idea of this blog?
 - a. Eating meat and fish is good for us and the planet.
 - b. People should be concerned about the planet's future.
 - c. Many healthy recipes can be prepared that are not totally based on meat.
 - d. Being a vegetarian is healthful—and is not as difficult as it first appears.

Reading for SylvanSync™
Grades 9–12
Blog

2. What is one way the writer suggests to make quick vegetarian meals?
 - a. make bowls of soup
 - b. go to cafes that have vegetables
 - c. eat only raw fruits and vegetables
 - d. buy packages of prepared vegetables
3. What do you think the writer of the blog will write about in the next posting?
 - a. vegetarian recipes
 - b. alternative protein
 - c. low-impact exercise
 - d. successful restaurants
4. What is the meaning of the word keen as it is used in the first paragraph?
 - a. extremely responsive
 - b. finely sharpened
 - c. piercing or biting
 - d. strongly desiring
5. How does the writer of the blog try to persuade the reader?
 - a. by supporting his point of view with specific details
 - b. by providing numerous tasty and healthy vegetarian recipes
 - c. by explaining how he personally is making changes to his diet
 - d. by developing a fear in the reader of eating too much meat and fish

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Blog

Part 3

Write a summary of the blog entry you read in Part 2 on your writing paper. Make sure that your response includes the elements of a summary. Your writing will be evaluated using the following 3-point rubric.

Writing Rubric

Score	Addresses the Topic	Supports the Summary Appropriately	Uses Correct Grammar, Capitalization, Punctuation, and Spelling
3	Targets the writing exactly to the topic. Does not shift focus.	Uses all characteristics of a summary.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout the summary.
2	Does a good job staying on topic. May wander or shift focus slightly.	Uses a few characteristics of a summary.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout some of the summary.
1	Does not address the topic at all.	Does not use appropriate characteristics of a summary.	There is no attempt at correct capitalization, punctuation, and spelling in the summary.

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Blog

Part 4

Write a blog entry that describes your thoughts and concerns about multicultural programs in your high school. Write your entry on your writing paper. Make sure that your response includes persuasive techniques to be convincing. Your writing will be evaluated using the following 3-point rubric.

Writing Rubric

Score	Addresses the Structure of a blog	Uses Persuasive Techniques Appropriately	Uses Correct Grammar, Capitalization, Punctuation, and Spelling
3	Targets the structure of the blog exactly.	Uses a persuasive technique in the blog.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout the blog.
2	Does a good job of targeting the structure of the blog but wanders a bit.	Uses some of the persuasive technique in the blog.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout some of the blog.
1	Does not address the structure of the blog at all.	Does not use a persuasive technique in the blog.	There is no attempt at correct capitalization, punctuation, and spelling in the blog.

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Print Advertisement

Objectives

The student will be able to:

- analyze the persuasive techniques of three print advertisements.
- create a print advertisement for one of the products.
- compare and contrast the new ad with the three print ads.

Materials

- paper
- markers
- writing paper

Background Information

You are exposed daily to persuasive media. Think about what you see on the Internet. Think about what you hear and see on the television. Everyone is trying to get you, as a consumer, to spend your money. **Advertisements** are created to let people know about a new product or service. The primary purpose of the advertiser is to persuade people to buy the product or to make use of the service.

Persuasion in advertising is about convincing others that the action of purchasing a product is correct and imperative. When advertisers try to persuade people to purchase, they sometimes use facts. Most often, however, advertisers use opinions and general statements to convince people to purchase.

The strategies an advertiser uses to persuade buyers are called **propaganda techniques**. Advertisements use propaganda techniques to influence people. The more aware you are of the techniques advertisers use to persuade you, the better you can judge whether their argument for purchasing the product is valid.

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Print Advertisement

Use the following chart to review the most common types of propaganda techniques used in advertising.

Persuasive Technique	Definition	Example
Bandwagon	suggesting that everyone is using the product	"Don't miss the weekend lineup on Channel 11, the station that everyone is watching."
Card Staking	showing only one side of an argument for a product	"In 80% of trials, Supersuds removed all of the stains from the clothes."
Glittering Generalities	using important-sounding but unspecific or false claims about a product	"We use the freshest ingredients in Jillian's Hot Dogs. Our hot dogs have a great taste that can't be beat!"
Loaded Words	using words that give a certain feeling about the product; words can be either positive or negative	Positive: unique, incredible, astonishing Negative: dirty, sad, heavy
Plain Folks	associating the use of the product with ordinary people with whom the buyer can relate	"Teenagers just like you use Vinca to treat their acne. Wouldn't you like a clear complexion too?"
Testimonial	using celebrities to endorse a product to make it appear attractive	"I always want to play my hardest, and UpBeat energy drink helps me be a star." (Spoken by a star player)
Transfer	associating a product with a symbol or image that people admire or love	"As good as grandma's home cooking on any night of the week."

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Grades 9–12

Print Advertisement

Critical analysis of advertising includes making **comparisons** and **contrasts**. Comparisons show similarities between people, objects, and events. Contrasts show the differences. Being able to compare and contrast advertisements requires you to understand the different features and how the advertiser used a persuasive technique to accomplish a specific purpose.

Activity

Complete the activities that follow on a separate sheet of paper.

Part 1

Write the name of the persuasive technique that is used in each sentence.

1. Our all-natural, healthful combination of nutrients and wholesome goodness is packed into every Healthola energy bar.
2. In 9 out of 10 tests completed, Smooth Shave was rated the best by all.
3. Mintastic gum: a blast of the Arctic in every bite!
4. All-time gold medal winner Betty Foster only wears Fog-free Water-View goggles.
5. Smooth Shave razors are perfect for a regular guy like me—and fit my budget.
6. Smooth Shave razors give you a clean and gentle shave.
7. There isn't anyone left who isn't shopping at the Riverside Mall.

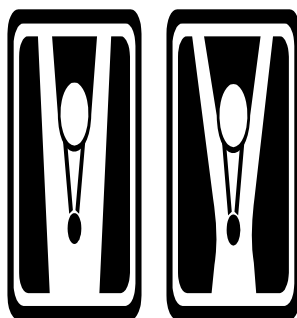
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Grades 9–12
Print Advertisement

Part 2

Read the following advertisements, and write the word(s) that indicate the persuasive technique used by the advertiser. There could be more than one used in the advertisement. Next to the words, write the name of the persuasive technique.

Advertisement 1

**All Gold-Medal Athletes wear Zoomer
Athletic Clothes**



**Feel like a gold-medal winner anytime!
Wear Zoomer!**



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Grades 9–12
Print Advertisement

Advertisement 2

**Car problems? People just like you
come to us each day.**



**We speak in down-to-earth language
that everyone understands.**

Our work is guaranteed completely.

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Print Advertisement

Advertisement 3

**Have the most
Amazing Vacation
of your life!**

**Tired
of the same old
vacation rounds?**



*Then come to
HAWAII~this time!*

**Who knows what incredible fun YOU will
have!**

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Grades 9–12

Print Advertisement

Part 3

Now it is your turn to be an advertiser. Create an advertisement for one of the products or services advertised in the three advertisements. You may use writing paper or paper and markers. Make sure that you include at least one persuasive technique in your advertisement. Your advertisement will be evaluated using the following 3-point rubric.

Writing Rubric

Score	Addresses the Structure of the Advertisement	Uses Persuasive Techniques Appropriately	Uses Correct Grammar, Capitalization, Punctuation, and Spelling
3	Targets the structure of the advertisement exactly.	Uses a persuasive technique in the advertisement.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout the advertisement.
2	Does a good job of targeting the structure of the advertisement but wanders a bit.	Uses some of the persuasive technique in the advertisement.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout some of the advertisement.
1	Does not address the structure of the advertisement at all.	Does not use a persuasive technique in the advertisement.	There is no attempt at correct capitalization, punctuation, and spelling in the advertisement.

Part 4

Compare and contrast the advertisement that you created with the three original advertisements. How are the persuasive techniques similar or different? Which advertisement is more effective and why? Write your answers on your writing paper.

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Poem

Objectives

The student will be able to:

- evaluate the use of figurative language in a poem.
- analyze the meaning of a poem.
- write your own poem in a similar style.

Materials

- writing paper

Background Information

Writers and poets often want to make their writing interesting for the reader. They will do this by using words to illustrate clear and creative images in the reader's mind. To do this, writers use different types of **figurative language**.

As readers, we are often required to read between the lines and interpret meaning in a text. This is because authors often use figurative language, such as **similes** and **metaphors**, to add depth and meaning to their work. These types of figurative language are used by a poet or an author to compare two unlike things. Similes make direct comparisons, using the words like or as to bring imagery to life. Metaphors make indirect comparisons and will often attempt to substitute another thing for the real subject.

Authors use **personification** to give human characteristics or traits to concepts, animals, or inanimate objects. Authors may choose to make an object seem alive or an animal seem human. Personification can be humorous, or it can show how we see ourselves in the world around us. Personification makes writing more fun and interesting. To recognize personification, first identify the object, concept, or animal in the sentence. Then find the verb, adjective, or adverb that the writer uses to give it human qualities.

Two types of figurative language that are useful in helping the reader "hear" what the writer describes are **onomatopoeia** and **alliteration**. In alliteration a consonant sound is repeated. In onomatopoeia the words sound like the objects they name or the sound that the objects make.

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Poem

Writers often use figurative language to make their words come alive and to actively involve the reader. With figurative language, such as **idioms** and **hyperbole**, the reader must think about what the writer really means because it is not always obvious. Idioms are expressions we use every day, often without realizing they are idioms. Idioms are expressions that don't literally mean exactly what they say. Often idioms come from sports, like "knock it out of the park." If you understand the game, you can probably figure out the meaning. Some idioms come from literature. Others have been around so long that no one is quite sure how they originated. You can often figure out the meaning from context. Hyperbole is an obvious exaggeration.

Use the following chart to help you remember the seven types of figurative language.

Figurative Language Types	Definition	Example
Simile	a comparison of two unlike things using either "like" or "as"	My little sister is as quiet as a mouse when she is being read to each night.
Metaphor	a comparison of two unlike things without using the words "like" or "as"	She has the heart of a lion.
Personification	giving a concept, animal, or inanimate object human qualities	The skyscraper tickled the clouds as they passed.
Idiom	a saying that means something different than the literal definition of the individual words	The homework was a piece of cake.
Hyperbole	an exaggerated statement that makes the reader have an emotional response	You snore louder than a freight train.
Alliteration	the repetition of a beginning consonant sound to create a feeling or add a musical or rhythmic feeling to the text	Patty planted pretty peonies in her garden.
Onomatopoeia	a word that imitates the sound it represents	rattle, roar, rumble, rustle

Reading for SylvanSync™
Grades 9–12
Poem

Activity

Complete the activities that follow on a separate sheet of paper.

Part 1

Read each sentence. On your paper, write the type of figurative language that is used.

1. We worried about the sputtering and clanking of the car's engine..
2. The clock screamed at me this morning when I overslept.
3. The child was as slow as a snail as he walked to school.
4. His comments added fuel to the fire.
5. Tina tweeted twice and then smiled as she anticipated the response.
6. I was sure that I was running faster than the speed of light in the race.
7. After the snowstorm, a white blanket covered the streets.

Part 2

Read the poem “The Moon is Distant from the Sea” by Emily Dickinson.

The Moon is Distant from the Sea

The moon is distant from the sea,
And yet with amber hands
She leads him, docile as a boy,
Along appointed sands.

He never misses a degree;
Obedient to her eye,
He comes just so far toward the town,
Just so far goes away.

Oh, Signor, thine the amber hand,
And mine the distant sea,—
Obedient to the least command
Thine eyes impose on me.

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Grades 9–12

Poem

Now answer these questions.

1. What type of figurative language is used by the poet in the first stanza?
2. What is the meaning of the poet's figurative language in the first stanza?
3. What is the meaning of this poem?

Part 3

Read the poem "A Madrigal" by William Shakespeare.

Crabbed Age and Youth
 Cannot live together:
 Youth is full of pleasance,
 Age is full of care;
 Youth like summer morn,
 Age like winter weather;
 Youth like summer brave,
 Age like winter bare:
 Youth is full of sports,
 Age's breath is short,
 Youth is nimble, Age is lame:
 Youth is hot and bold,
 Age is weak and cold,
 Youth is wild, and Age is tame:—
 Age, I do abhor thee;
 Youth, I do adore thee;
 O! my Love, my Love is young!
 Age, I do defy thee—
 O sweet shepherd, hie thee,
 For methinks thou stay'st too long.

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Now answer these questions.

1. What type of figurative language is used by the poet in the fifth line?
2. What is the meaning of the poet's figurative language in the fifth line?
3. What is the meaning of this poem?

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Grades 9–12

Poem

Part 4

On your paper write a sentence for each of the seven different types of figurative language described in this lesson. Identify the type of figurative language for each sentence.

Part 5

Now it is your turn to be a poet. Write a poem in the style of Dickinson or Shakespeare. Make sure that you include at least two types of figurative language in your poem. Your poem will be evaluated using the following 3-point rubric. Write your poem on your paper.

Writing Rubric

Score	Addresses the Structure of the Poem	Uses Figurative Language Appropriately	Uses Correct Grammar, Capitalization, Punctuation, and Spelling
3	Targets the structure of the poem exactly.	Uses several appropriate examples of figurative language in the poem.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout the poem.
2	Does a good job of targeting the structure of the poem but wanders a bit.	Uses a few appropriate examples of figurative language in the poem.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout some of the poem.
1	Does not address the structure of the poem at all.	Does not use appropriate examples of figurative language in the poem.	There is no attempt at correct capitalization, punctuation, and spelling.

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Science Fiction

Objectives

The student will be able to:

- analyze the style and genre characteristics of science fiction.
- write a science fiction story.

Materials

- writing paper
- markers

Background Information

Science fiction is a literary form that blends reality and science into a fictional story. It tells about imaginary events and typically involves science or technology. Many science fiction stories are set in the future or in an alternate universe. The story is the author's point of view or ideas as to what the future might be or the anticipations of what it will be. The author usually takes aspects of regular life and then stretches them through a vivid imagination. Stories about space travel and UFOs blend fact and fiction into an exhilarating and wonder-filled story.

Many movies today are science fiction stories that trigger the viewers' imagination and challenge what is thought to be real. Is time travel possible? Can dinosaurs be cloned? Is an asteroid headed to impact Earth? These types of science-based questions added to some imagination create good science fiction stories. Many times, science fiction does eventually become science fact. One hundred years ago, a science fiction writer, Jules Verne, wrote books about ships that sail beneath the water and ships that sail to the stars. One hundred years later, submarines and space shuttles are part of our real world!

- **Setting:** The story might occur in the far future or distant past. The action may occur on another planet or on a spaceship.
- **Characters:** The characters may be aliens from outer space that visit us on Earth. Beings with non-human appearance and actions that possess human qualities are portrayed. Humans may be described as having superhuman powers.
- **Plot:** The storyline may involve technology not yet invented or strange interactions and weird conflicts. Space exploration is depicted that goes far beyond the capabilities of man as we know it today.

1. The setting is always depicted as being in the future.
 - a. true
 - b. false
2. Aliens are always the major or minor characters.
 - a. true
 - b. false
3. People might be given incredible powers.
 - a. true
 - b. false
4. The plot might include technology that has yet to be invented.
 - a. true
 - b. false
5. The plot is always a combination of something that is known and something unknown.
 - a. true
 - b. false

Reading for SylvanSync™
Grades 9–12
Science Fiction

Part 2

Read the adapted excerpt of the science fiction story “The Time Traveler” by H.G. Wells. While you are reading, take notes on the parts that show that it is a piece of science fiction writing.

The Time Traveler

The Time Traveler was expounding an obscure matter to us. He put it to us marking points with a lean forefinger—as we admired his earnestness after eating a big dinner in a room lit by the fireplace.

“You must follow me carefully. I shall have to controvert ideas that are almost universally accepted. Geometry is founded on a misconception. You know of course that a line of thickness has no real existence. Neither has a mathematical plane. These things are mere abstractions.”

“That is all right,” said the Psychologist.

“Nor, having only length, breadth, and thickness, can a cube have a real existence.”

“There I object,” said Filby. “Of course a solid body may exist. All real things—”

“So people think. But wait a moment. Can an instantaneous cube exist?”

“Don't follow you,” said Filby.

“Can a cube that does not last for any time at all, have a real existence?”

Filby became pensive.

“Clearly,” the Time Traveler proceeded, “any real body must have extension in four directions: it must have Length, Breadth, Thickness, and Duration. But we incline to overlook this fact. There are really four dimensions, three which we call the three planes of Space, and a fourth, Time. There is a tendency to draw an unreal distinction between the former three dimensions and the latter, because it happens that our consciousness moves intermittently in one direction along the latter from the beginning to the end of our lives.”

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Science Fiction

“Now, it is very remarkable that this is so extensively overlooked,” continued the Time Traveler. “Really this is what is meant by the Fourth Dimension. It is only another way of looking at Time. There is no difference between Time and any of the three dimensions of Space except that our consciousness moves along it. But some foolish people have got hold of the wrong side of that idea. Space, as our mathematicians have it, is spoken of as having three dimensions. But some philosophical people have been asking why three dimensions particularly—why not another direction at right angles to the other three? Well, I do not mind telling you I have been at work upon the Four Dimensions for some time. For instance, here is a portrait of a man at eight years old, another at fifteen, another at seventeen, another at twenty-three, and so on. All these are evidently sections. Three-Dimensional representations of his Four-Dimensioned being, which is a fixed and unalterable thing.”

“But,” said the Medical Man, staring at the fire, “if Time is really only a fourth dimension of Space, why has it always been regarded as something different? Why cannot we move in Time as we move about in the other dimensions of Space?”

The Time Traveler smiled. “Are you sure we can move freely in Space? Right and left we can go, backward and forward freely enough. I admit we move freely in two dimensions. But how about up and down? Gravitation limits us.”

“You cannot move at all in Time, you cannot get away from the now.”

“That is just where you are wrong. We are always getting away from the present moment.”

“But the great difficulty is this,” interrupted the Psychologist. “You can move about in all directions of Space, but you cannot move about in Time.”

“That is the germ of my great discovery. You are wrong to say that we cannot move about in Time. If I am recalling an incident vividly I go back to the instant of its occurrence: I become absent-minded. I jump back for a moment. Of course we have no means of staying back for any length of Time. He can go up against gravitation in a balloon, and why should he not hope that ultimately he may be able to stop or accelerate his drift along the Time-Dimension, or even turnabout and travel the other way?”

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Science Fiction

“Oh, this,” began Filby, “is all—”

“Why not?” said the Time Traveler.

“It's against reason,” said Filby.

“What reason?” said the Time Traveler.

“You can show black is white,” said Filby, “but you will never convince me.”

“Possibly not,” said the Time Traveler. “But now you begin to see the object of my investigations into the Four Dimensions. Long ago I had a vague inkling of a machine—”

“To travel through Time!” exclaimed the Very Young Man.

“That shall travel in any direction of Space and Time, as the driver determines. I have experimental verification,” said the Time Traveler.

“Experimental verification!” cried I. “You are going to verify that?”

The Time Traveler smiled and walked slowly out of the room, and we heard his slippers shuffling down the long passage to his laboratory.

The Psychologist looked at us. “I wonder what he's got.”

“Some trick or other,” said the Medical Man, and Filby tried to tell us about a magician he had seen; but before he finished the Time Traveler returned.

The Time Traveler held in his hand a glittering metallic framework, scarcely larger than a small clock, and delicate. There was ivory and some transparent crystalline substance. On a table he placed the mechanism.

The only other object on the table was a small lamp, the bright light fell upon the model. I sat in a chair nearest, and I drew forward so as to be almost between the Time Traveler and the fireplace. Filby sat behind him, looking over his shoulder. The Medical Man and the Mayor watched him from the right, the Psychologist from the left. The Very Young Man stood behind the Psychologist. It appears incredible to me that any kind of trick could have been played upon us under these conditions.

The Time Traveler looked at us, and then at the mechanism. “Well?” said the Psychologist.

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Science Fiction

“This little affair,” said the Time Traveler, “is only a model. It is my plan for a machine to travel through time. You will notice that it looks there is a twinkling appearance, as though it was in some way unreal.” He pointed to the part with his finger. “Also, here is one little white lever, and here is another. I want you to understand that this lever, being pressed over, sends the machine gliding into the future, and this other reverses the motion. This saddle represents the seat of a time Traveler. I am going to press the lever, and off the machine will go. It will vanish, pass into future Time, and disappear. Have a good look and satisfy yourselves there is no trickery.”

There was a minute's pause. Then the Time Traveler put his finger toward the lever. “No,” he said suddenly. “Lend me your hand.” And turning to the Psychologist, took that individual's hand and told him to put out his forefinger. So it was the Psychologist who sent forth the Time Machine on its voyage. We all saw the lever turn. I am absolutely certain there was no trickery. There was a breath of wind, and the lamp flame jumped. The little machine suddenly swung round, became indistinct, was seen as a ghost for a second perhaps; and it was gone—vanished! Save for the lamp the table was bare.

Everyone was silent for a minute. We stared at each other. “Look here,” said the Medical Man, “do you seriously believe that that machine has traveled into time?”

“Certainly,” said the Time Traveler. What is more, I have a big machine nearly finished in there,” he indicated the laboratory, “and when that is put together I mean to have a journey on my own. Would you like to see the Time Machine?” He led the way down the corridor to his laboratory. There in the laboratory we beheld a larger edition of the little mechanism which we had seen vanish from before our eyes. Parts were of nickel, parts of ivory, parts had certainly been filed or sawn out of rock crystal. The thing was generally complete, but the twisted crystalline bars lay unfinished upon the bench beside some sheets of drawings, and I took one up for a better look at it. Quartz it seemed to be.

“Upon that machine,” said the Time Traveler, “I intend to explore time. Is that plain?”

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Science Fiction

Now answer these questions.

1. What makes this science fiction story science?
2. Write one or two sentences that could be added to the second to last paragraph that would add an element of science fiction.
3. What is the main idea of this story?
 - a. Time travel is proposed and is demonstrated.
 - b. The Time Traveler has created amazing magic.
 - c. People are doubtful of the reality of time travel.
 - d. The characters accept the principles of four dimensions.
4. Which event in the story was something that is presently unknown?
 - a. changes to the polar caps
 - b. theories about the movement in time
 - c. the demonstration of the time machine
 - d. the properties of the crystalline substance
5. What is a reasonable prediction of what might happen next in the story?
 - a. The Time Traveler's friends will pay him for the machine.
 - b. The Time Traveler will ask the Very Young Man to test the machine.
 - c. The Time Traveler will test his machine and disappear only to return again.
 - d. The Time Traveler will be put in jail for the development of deadly machine.

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Science Fiction

Part 3

On your paper, complete a story map like the one below for “The Time Traveler.”

Setting: Where:
When:
Major Characters:
Minor Characters:
Plot/Problem:
Event 1:
Event 2:
Event 3:
Outcome:

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Grades 9–12

Science Fiction

Part 4

Write a science fiction story on your writing paper. Make sure that your story includes the characteristics of science fiction. You may illustrate your story. Your writing will be evaluated using the following 3-point rubric.

Writing Rubric

Score	Addresses the Topic	Supports the Topic Appropriately	Uses Correct Grammar, Capitalization, Punctuation, and Spelling
3	Targets the writing exactly to the topic. Does not shift focus.	Uses several appropriate characteristics of the genre to support the main topic.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout the writing.
2	Does a good job staying on topic. May wander or shift focus slightly.	Uses a few characteristics of the genre to support the main topic.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout some of the writing.
1	Does not address the topic at all.	Does not use appropriate characteristics of the genre to support the topic.	There is no attempt at correct capitalization, punctuation, and spelling in the writing.

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Realistic Fiction

Objectives

The student will be able to:

- analyze the style and genre characteristics of realistic fiction.
- write a realistic fiction story.

Materials

- highlighter
- writing paper
- markers

Background Information

Fiction is a category of literature that describes imaginary people, locations, and events with the primary purpose of entertaining the reader. **Realistic fiction** is a literary form in which the stories, passages, and novels could actually happen in real life. They are based on everyday characters and events that could actually exist. Authors use imagined characters, settings, and plots which are often based on reality, so realistic fiction can seem as true as any documentary that is viewed on television. These are stories with events that could take place in modern times and could actually happen.

These points will help you to identify writing that is realistic fiction.

- **Characters:** The characters are depicted as ordinary and real people. The characters usually change as a result of a problem that is developed in the plot, and they need a resolution to the problem by the conclusion of the passage.
- **Setting:** The place is imaginary, but it could actually exist.
- **Plot:** The plot must be plausible and believable to the reader. There are usually problems, puzzling happenings, or dilemmas for characters to resolve. A reader will usually feel that the passage really could happen or the reader may want to believe that it did.
- **Theme:** Themes that an author will develop include those that all people typically deal with at some point in life such as good versus bad. The events usually raise moral questions that the reader might need to resolve in real life.
- **Style and Tone:** The author usually uses literary devices such as foreshadowing to rouse the reader's curiosity in the events that unfold in the passage.

Reading for SylvanSync™
Grades 9–12
Realistic Fiction

Activity

Complete the activities that follow on a separate sheet of paper.

Part 1

Answer the following questions about the style and characteristics of realistic fiction passages.

1. The setting is usually fantastical.
a. true b. false
2. The characters are based on individuals who are recognized for their historical importance.
a. true b. false
3. The characters in a realistic fiction have experiences comparable to the reader or ones that are plausible.
a. true b. false
4. The plot includes events that the reader can conclude are real.
a. true b. false

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Realistic Fiction

Part 2

Read the adapted excerpt from chapter one of the novel *My Antonia* by Willa Cather. While you are reading, take notes on the parts that show that it is a piece of realistic fiction.

My Antonia

I first heard of Antonia on an interminable journey across the great midland plain of North America. I was ten years old then; I had lost both my father and mother within a year, and my Virginia relatives were sending me out to my grandparents, who lived in Nebraska. I traveled in the care of a mountain boy, Jake Marpole, one of the “hands” on my father's old farm under the Blue Ridge, who was now going West to work for my grandfather. Jake's experience of the world was not much wider than mine.

He had never been in a train until the morning when we set out together to try our fortunes in a new world. Beyond Chicago we were under the protection of a friendly conductor, who knew all about the country to which we were going and gave us a great deal of advice in exchange for our confidence. He seemed to us an experienced and worldly man who had been almost everywhere; in his conversation he threw out lightly the names of distant states and cities. He wore the rings and pins and badges of different fraternal orders to which he belonged. Even his cuff-buttons were engraved with hieroglyphics.

Once when he sat down to chat, he told us that in the car ahead there was a family from “across the water” whose destination was the same as ours. “They can't any of them speak English, except one little girl, and all she can say is “We go Black Hawk, Nebraska.” She's not much older than you, twelve or thirteen, maybe, and she's as bright as a new dollar. Don't you want to go ahead and see her, Jimmy? She's got the pretty brown eyes, too!”

This last remark made me bashful, and I shook my head. Jake nodded at me approvingly and said you were likely to get diseases from foreigners. I do not remember crossing the Missouri River, or anything about the long day's journey through Nebraska. Probably by that time I had crossed so many rivers that I was dull to them. The only thing very noticeable about Nebraska was that it was still, all day long.

I had been sleeping, for a long while when we reached Black Hawk. Jake roused me and took me by the hand. We stumbled down from the train to a wooden siding, where men were running about. I couldn't see any town,

Reading for SylvanSync™
Grades 9–12
Realistic Fiction

or even distant lights; we were surrounded by what seemed to be utter darkness. The engine was panting heavily after its long run. In the red glow from the engine, a group of people stood huddled together on the platform, encumbered by bundles and boxes. I knew this must be the immigrant family the conductor had told us about. The woman wore a fringed shawl tied over her head, and she carried a little trunk in her arms, hugging it as if it were a baby. There was an old man, tall and stooped. Two half-grown boys and a girl stood holding bundles, and a little girl clung to her mother's skirts. Presently a man approached them and began to talk, shouting and exclaiming. I pricked up my ears, for it was positively the first time I had ever heard a foreign tongue.

A bantering voice called out: "Hello, are you Mr. Burden's folks? If you are, it's me you're looking for. I'm Otto Fuchs. I'm Mr. Burden's hired man, and I'm to drive you out. Hello, Jimmy, ain't you scared to come so far west?" I looked up with interest at the new face in the light. He told us we had a long night drive ahead of us, and had better get going. He led us to the parking lot where there were two trucks parked. I saw the foreign family crowding into one of them. The other was for us. Jake got in the front seat with Otto Fuchs, and I rode in the back in the truck bed. The immigrants rumbled off into the empty darkness, and we followed them.

I tried to go to sleep, but the jolting made me bite my tongue, and I soon began to ache all over. I had a hard bed. Cautiously I got up on my knees and peered over the side of the truck. There seemed to be nothing to see; no fences, no creeks or trees, no hills or fields. If there was a road, I could not make it out in the faint starlight. There was nothing but land: not a country at all, but the material out of which countries are made. No, there was nothing but land—slightly undulating, I knew, because often our wheels ground against the brake as we went down into a hollow and lurched up again on the other side. I had the feeling that the world was left behind, that we had got over the edge of it, and were outside man's jurisdiction. I had never before looked up at the sky when there was not a familiar mountain ridge against it. But this was the complete dome of heaven, all there was of it. I did not believe that my dead father and mother were watching me from up there; they would still be looking for me at the sheep-fold down by the creek, or along the white road that led to the mountain pastures. I had left even their spirits behind me. The truck jolted on, carrying me I knew not where. I don't think I was homesick. If we never arrived anywhere, it did not matter. Between that earth and that sky I felt erased.

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Grades 9–12
Realistic Fiction

Now answer these questions.

1. What makes this a realistic fiction passage?
2. Write one or two sentences that could be added to paragraphs 1 or 2 that would add an element of realistic fiction.
3. What is the main idea of this chapter of the novel?
 - a. A young boy leaves his family home and travels west.
 - b. Two people traveling on a train have a great adventure.
 - c. Immigrants are traveling west to resettle in a foreign land.
 - d. Travel in Nebraska is different than in the Blue Ridge mountains.
4. Which sentence from the story foreshadows what might happen in the novel?
 - a. I had been sleeping, for a long while.
 - b. Even his cuff-buttons were engraved with hieroglyphics.
 - c. This last remark made me bashful, and I shook my head.
 - d. Jake's experience of the world was not much wider than mine.
5. What do you predict will happen in the next chapter?
 - a. The narrator recounts his train adventure to his new friends.
 - b. The narrator becomes homesick and returns to his relatives in Virginia.
 - c. The narrator meets his grandparents and begins to experience a farm in Nebraska.
 - d. The narrator rides his bicycle over to the next farm and meets the immigrant family.

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Realistic Fiction

Part 3

On a piece of paper, complete a story map like the one below for *My Antonia*.

Setting: Where: When:
Major Characters: Minor Characters:
Plot/Problem:
Event 1:
Event 2:
Event 3:
Outcome:

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Realistic Fiction

Part 4

Write a realistic fiction story on your writing paper. Make sure that your story includes the characteristics of realistic fiction. You may illustrate your story. Your writing will be evaluated using the following 3-point rubric.

Writing Rubric

Score	Addresses the Topic	Supports the Topic Appropriately	Uses Correct Grammar, Capitalization, Punctuation, and Spelling
3	Targets the writing exactly to the topic. Does not shift focus.	Uses several appropriate characteristics of the genre to support the main topic.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout the writing.
2	Does a good job staying on topic. May wander or shift focus slightly.	Uses a few characteristics of the genre to support the main topic.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout some of the writing.
1	Does not address the topic at all.	Does not use appropriate characteristics of the genre to support the topic.	There is no attempt at correct capitalization, punctuation, and spelling in the writing.

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Travel Brochure

Objectives

The student will be able to:

- analyze an author's use of descriptive detail.
- create a travel brochure for a favorite place, real or imagined.

Materials

- paper
- markers

Background Information

Effective writers include descriptive details in order to help the reader “see,” “feel,” “taste,” “smell,” and “hear” the details in the story. Have you heard the saying “show, don’t tell” when you’re writing? This means that a writer should use words to paint a picture to make readers feel like they are actually in the story. Think about writing that you like and remember. It was probably full of descriptive details. In nonfiction writing, such as travel brochures or advertisements, writers will use descriptive details to persuade people to take a trip or buy a product.

Travel brochures are created by resorts, countries, states, and cities to inform potential visitors of the interesting and exciting highlights of the area. These include parks, beaches, museums, and culture of the area. Additionally, a travel brochure will include important information on travel to the area, accommodations, restaurants, and maps. These brochures are created in a variety of formats: tri-fold, one-page flyer, multi-page brochure, postcard, poster, or a folder with many of these formats. All of these will include sensory details to paint a picture of the destination that will entice the potential tourist to come and visit.

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Grades 9–12

Travel Brochure

Activity

Complete the activities that follow on a separate sheet of paper.

Part 1

Read the following travel brochure.

 This is your year to finally experience travel through one of the world's most amazing structures—The Panama Canal! On your trip you will cruise through the vibrant blue waters of the Caribbean. You can visit numerous islands rich with delectable foods and culture. You will be drawn into cafes by the aroma of fried Yucca root and tamales. Be dazzled by the green of the island and the white sandy beaches.	 Enjoy a leisurely swim in the warm salt water. Kayak in quiet coves with only the sound of lapping waves on the shore.  Make your winter a time of warmth, adventure, and enchantment!
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Grades 9–12
Travel Brochure

Now answer these questions.

1. On your paper, fill in a chart like the following. Cite one detail that relates to each sense.

Sense	Detail from Brochure
Sight	
Smell	
Touch	
Taste	
Sound	

2. Which sense was used the most in the travel brochure?
3. Why do you think that this sense was used the most?

Part 2

What details could be added to the travel brochure for Panama and the West Indies to make it more vivid for a potential tourist?

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Grades 9–12
Travel Brochure

Part 3

Read each pair of sentences and write the letter of the sentence that provides the most detail.

1. a. Eduardo has become renowned worldwide due to his creative and inventive art.
b. Eduardo is now recognized by most people as a great artist when they see his work.
2. a. Smart weather forecasters are able to tell that the summer will be hot.
b. Perceptive weather forecasters predict that this will be another wickedly torrid summer.
3. a. He spoke quickly and the words that came out of his mouth were hurtful to any person within hearing distance.
b. Heated words spun out of his mouth like a rapidly rotating whirlwind inflicting grief and pain on those who crossed his path.
4. a. The larks' songs are the sounds of flutes creating an ethereal quality that is both tranquil and delightful.
b. The sound of the lark's song is a pleasing and relaxing sound similar to the flute section in the orchestra.
5. a. As the knave began to bow down in front of the monarch, bells began to ring from atop the castle's rock bell tower.
b. The valiant knave bowed before the monarch in knightly submission as the pealing of the bells could be heard in the distance.

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Grades 9–12

Travel Brochure

Part 4

On your paper, fill in a chart like the one below. Above your chart, write the name of your favorite vacation spot (real or imagined). Then, using the sensory detail chart, brainstorm some details that would describe your favorite vacation spot.

Favorite Vacation Spot

Sense	<i>Details</i>
Visual / See	
Sounds	
Tastes	
Textures / Touch	
Smells	

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Grades 9–12

Travel Brochure

Part 5

Now think about what a travel agent does. Think about what a vacation destination would do to convince people to come and stay. Create a travel brochure for your favorite place, real or imagined. The brochure can be a tri-fold, one-page flyer, multi-page brochure, postcard, poster, or a folder. You may use writing paper or paper and markers. Make sure that you include appropriate and descriptive details in your travel brochure. Your travel brochure will be evaluated using the following 3-point rubric.

Writing Rubric

Score	Addresses the Structure of the Travel Brochure	Uses Details Appropriately	Uses Correct Grammar, Capitalization, Punctuation, and Spelling
3	Targets the structure of the travel brochure exactly.	Uses many appropriate details in the travel brochure.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout the travel brochure.
2	Does a good job of targeting the structure of the travel brochure but wanders a bit.	Uses some details in the travel brochure.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout some of the travel brochure.
1	Does not address the structure of the travel brochure at all.	Does not use details in the travel brochure.	There is no attempt at correct capitalization, punctuation, and spelling in the travel brochure.

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Movie Review

Objectives

The student will be able to:

- evaluate a movie review.
- analyze the writer's tone, voice, authority, and persuasiveness.
- write a review of a movie.

Materials

- writing paper

Background Information

A **movie review** is a short description aimed at providing potential viewers with information about the strengths and weaknesses of a movie. This helps potential viewers decide whether to see the movie. Writing a movie review is a great way to express your opinion about a movie. Learning how to write a movie review will enhance your appreciation of films.

A review should give enough details about the movie that the reader can make a wise decision. A review should not give anyway any essential details, such as twists in the plot or the ending. Movie reviews are typically 250 to 500 words and have the following format:

1. An **introduction** gives background information, such as the type of film, cast, director, main characters, and setting.
2. A **body** deals with key plot elements as well as comments on the editing, directing, lighting, music, and character development.
3. A **conclusion** is mainly your opinion about whether the film is worth watching. Include your opinions of the direction, script, actors, and photography. You should also give impartial details, and allow readers to make up their own minds. Opinions or claims should be supported to allow readers to determine whether they would agree with you.

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Grades 9–12

Movie Review

Below are guidelines and tips for writing a good movie review.

1. Select the movie you want to review. First, get to know a little about it. What have the actors and director done previously? You might want to watch some of their prior movies. Are they Oscar winners? Are they known for a certain style? Is the movie based on a book or a historical event? Is it a remake or a sequel?
2. See the movie. You may even want to watch the movie a second time. Watching the movie a second time will help you recall more details.
3. Take notes during the film. Write down the names of the stars, director, and screenwriter. Note the running time and the rating.
4. Take time to let the film soak in. Think about it for a while before you begin writing. Let your likes or dislikes wear off a bit so your writing won't be too emotional.
5. Identify your audience. Is the review for a school newspaper, or is it for a film magazine? Ensure you report on the elements of the movie that matter to your likely audience.
6. Now you can write. Develop your opinion in one sentence. Your job as movie reviewer is to give your opinion of the movie. Your opinion will be the basis of your movie review.
7. Next, write the introduction. Most movie review readers like to be entertained, so think up a good line to hook the reader.
8. Let your draft sit for a few hours; then review and edit it.

Reading for SylvanSync™
Grades 9–12
Movie Review

Activity

Complete the activities that follow on a separate sheet of paper.

Part 1

Answer the following questions about the elements of a movie review.

1. Taking notes during the movie will help you remember details.
a. true b. false
2. A movie review is written for the purpose of getting people to see the movie.
a. true b. false
3. In the body of the review only key plot elements are described.
a. true b. false
4. Obtaining information about other films by the director will help you write the review.
a. true b. false

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Grades 9–12

Movie Review

Part 2

Read the following movie review of *Jane Eyre*. Take notes on key words that will help you evaluate and analyze the review.

“A love story as fiercely intelligent as it is passionate.” This tagline from the movie says it all. With over 25 film adaptations of the classic Charlotte Bronte novel, viewers could argue endlessly about which one is the best. This version will undoubtedly rise to the top of the heap in that debate. I have watched all 25 film adaptations and have read *Jane Eyre* numerous times—as well as all of Charlotte Bronte’s books. The cast of this film is led by Oscar Award winner Dame Judi Dench, Mia Wasikowska, and Michael Fassbender. The cast is directed skillfully by Cary Fukunaga, who has made an abrupt turn from his direction of *Sin Nombre*. In this version of *Jane Eyre*, Fukunaga recalls the 1943 version starring Orson Welles and Joan Fontaine, particularly the vivid scenery.

This adaptation covers Jane’s childhood, her time at Lowood, the visit by Blanche Ingram, Jane’s visit to her sick aunt, and the dramatic ending. The movie condenses far too much of the book, and the ending is quite abrupt. Wasikowska’s portrayal of Jane is very close to the character that Bronte created. Cary Fukunaga’s emphasis on the Gothic elements of the novel elevates this adaptation to the top of the heap. It is a bit dark in places, but remember that this is a Gothic romance novel. The cinematography of the English countryside is exceptional. Costumes are extraordinary examples of the Gothic time period. The development of the characters is a bit lacking due to the fact that the movie cut so much from the book.

Despite a lot being left out from the book, which one could argue happens in every book-turned-movie, this is most definitely the best adaptation I have had the pleasure of viewing. The actors are all incredible and give new depth to each character, and the cinematography covers the film in beautiful lighting that the novel deserves. It’s a breath of fresh air for Romantic period pieces. Overall, the cast is so undeniably impressive, especially Wasikowska who truly cements her talent here, especially in her scenes with Fassbender, that it makes up for anything that was omitted. This movie is excellent if you’re a fan of the novel, or if you’re in the mood for a haunting Romantic period piece.

Reading for SylvanSync™
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Movie Review

Now answer these questions.

1. Which genre of movie is reviewed?
 - a. action
 - b. adventure
 - c. comedy
 - d. drama
2. Which part of the movie does the review like the best?
 - a. Scenes that included Dame Judi Dench.
 - b. The scene with the visit by Blanche Ingram.
 - c. Scenes that included both Wasikowska and Fassbender.
 - d. The scene when Jane went alone to visit her sick aunt.
3. What is the reviewer's overall rating of the movie?
 - a. one star out of five
 - b. two stars out of five
 - c. three stars out of five
 - d. four stars out of five

Reading for SylvanSync™
Grades 9–12
Movie Review

Part 3

On a piece of paper, fill in a chart like the one below to note the movie reviewer's claims in one column and supporting details or evidence in the other. If there are no supporting details to support a claim, write none in the column. Then answer the question that follows.

Claims	Supporting Details

1. Does the reviewer adequately support claims in the review? Explain. Write your response on your writing paper.

Part 4

Answer the following questions on your paper.

1. Does the reviewer reveal too much or too little about the film's plot? Support your answer with specific details.
2. What is the reviewer's tone or voice in the review?
3. How does the reviewer establish his or her authority to write this review?
4. What details did the reviewer not include that are typically found in a movie review?
5. What additional questions do you have about the movie?

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Movie Review

Part 5

Write a movie review on your writing paper. Make sure that your review includes the elements of a movie review and support your claims and opinion. Your writing will be evaluated using the following 3-point rubric.

Writing Rubric

Score	Addresses the Topic	Supports the Topic Appropriately	Uses Correct Grammar, Capitalization, Punctuation, and Spelling
3	Targets the writing exactly to the topic. Does not shift focus.	Uses several appropriate characteristics of the genre to support the main topic.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout the writing.
2	Does a good job staying on topic. May wander or shift focus slightly.	Uses a few characteristics of the genre to support the main topic.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout some of the writing.
1	Does not address the topic at all.	Does not use appropriate characteristics of the genre to support the topic.	There is no attempt at correct capitalization, punctuation, and spelling in the writing.

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Music Review

Objectives

The student will be able to:

- evaluate a review of a concert or CD.
- analyze the writer's tone, voice, authority, and persuasiveness.
- write an authoritative review of a concert or CD.

Materials

- writing paper

Background Information

A **music review** is a short narrative designed to provide potential listeners with information about the strengths and weaknesses of the music of a particular CD or a concert. This helps listeners decide whether they want to listen to the music and/or attend a concert of the performers in the future. Learning how to write a music review will enhance your appreciation of diverse types of music.

A review should give sufficient details about the music so that the listener can make a wise decision. Music reviews are typically 250 to 500 words and have the following format:

1. An **introduction** gives background information, such as who is in the band, what type of music have they performed in previous albums, how many tracks the current CD has, and some of the song titles. If it is about a concert, you need to describe the location, the audience, how many songs were played, and any other details that might be interesting to the reader. Think about the questions: who, what, when, where, and why.
2. A main **body** deals with specific tracks that you feel strongly about and which tracks you disliked. Bring your impressions and point of view alive. Describe the music at the concert performance.
3. A **conclusion** is mainly your opinion about whether the CD or concert is worthy of your listening time or of purchasing it. Write specifically about the CD or concert you are reviewing, not as much about the band itself or its past CDs. You should give impartial details in order to allow readers to make up their own minds. Support your opinions and claims with factual information that back up your opinions.

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Music Review

Below are guidelines and tips for writing a good music review.

1. Select the music you want to review or choose a concert to attend. First, get to know a little about the music and the band. What has the band done previously? Perhaps listen to some of their prior CDs. Are they Grammy winners? Are they known for a certain style?
2. Listen to the CD a few times. Listening to the music a few times will help you feel the tempo and rhythm, understand the lyrics, and appreciate other elements of the music.
3. Take notes while listening to the music. Study the cover and inside notes. Note the running time and title of the tracks. Note the tracks that stand out for being great or terrible.
4. Take time to let the music soak in. Think about it for a while before you begin writing. Let your likes or dislikes wear off a bit so your writing won't be too passionate.
5. Identify your audience. Is it for a school newspaper review or is it for music buffs? Ensure you report on the elements of the music that matter to your likely audience.
6. Now you can write. Develop your opinion in one sentence. Your job as a music reviewer is to give your opinion of the music. This may come down to the typical "thumbs up" or "three stars out of five." Develop your opinion that will be the foundation of your music review.
7. Next write the introduction. Most music review readers like to be entertained, so think up a good line to hook the reader.
8. Let your review sit for a few hours, then review it and edit.

Complete the activities that follow on a separate sheet of paper.

Answer the following questions about the elements of a music review.

1. Taking notes while listening to the music will help you remember specific details of the tracks.
 - a. true
 - b. false
2. A music review is written for the purpose of getting people to buy the CD or to attend the concert.
 - a. true
 - b. false
3. The reviewer's opinion is typically included in the introduction.
 - a. true
 - b. false
4. In the body of the review all CD tracks are discussed.
 - a. true
 - b. false
5. Obtaining information about other CDs by the musicians will help you write the review.
 - a. true
 - b. false

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Music Review

Part 2

Read the following music review of the debut CD *The Band Perry* by The Band Perry. Note key words that will help you answer questions that evaluate and analyze the review.

If you're tired of the country sound, you need look no further than The Band Perry to find something new. The sibling trio brings freshness to the country music scene that hasn't been heard for a long time. Kimberly Perry sings lead, in addition to playing piano and guitar. Her brother Reid Perry is the bassist, while Neil Perry plays drums, mandolin, and accordion. This is a credible example of original music. The Band Perry's debut features producers Nathan Chapman and Paul Worley, who resisted the urge to pump up their sound on this pop-country effort. The vocals, the lyrics, and the music add up to brilliant young artists. It only took 20 minutes to sell out for The Band Perry's first headlining show in Nashville, TN. This response echoes the overwhelming welcome the trio has received by fans nationwide since the release of their CD.

The band walks the line between country-pop and traditional country and pulls it off. "If I Die Young" is an unbelievable piece by these young artists. The strongest track by far, it is one of the saddest songs released in years. This track will give you goose bumps. Kimberly is wailing and aching. It's the sincerity, not vocal prowess, that makes this track. Love songs are the band's forte. "Hip to My Heart" is a lighthearted ode to a new crush that's dulled by silly lyrics but saved by nice fiddle work. They continue the romancing on the surprisingly good Kara Dioguardi co-written, "Postcards from Paris," which incorporates fiddle and mandolin to the pop sound. "Quittin' Your" is driving rock, with just a bit of southern twang. "All Your Life" will hold more appeal for traditional country music fans, due to gentle mandolin and dobro. The track "Double Heart" mixes in a few rock elements with country music, and the results are interesting. The only song I don't like is "Lasso;" it just feels slow.

Reading for SylvanSync™
Grades 9–12
Music Review

I encourage everyone to listen to this band. The CD is a great start for such a young band. It is well written and executed throughout. Kimberly Perry's voice is a lovely mix of sweet and salty. With fresh, vibrant instrumentation, the brothers also blend in the vocal harmonies of pros. While I delight in their innocence, I can't wait for this band to mature. Kim will become polished and the brothers will tighten their sound, maybe add more harmony. There isn't really one song that sums up the album because each track brings something unique. Give The Band Perry a chance! You won't regret it. Listening to this CD will most likely make you cry, laugh, and dance. To me, that's a CD worth buying! I believe The Band Perry will be around for a very long time.

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Music Review

Now answer these questions.

1. Which genre of music is reviewed?
 - a. blues
 - b. country
 - c. hip-hop
 - d. pop
2. Which song does the reviewer like the best?
 - a. "All Your Life"
 - b. "Double Heart"
 - c. "If I Die Young"
 - d. "Postcards from Paris"
3. Which song does the reviewer like the least?
 - a. "Hip to My Heart"
 - b. "Lasso"
 - c. "Postcards from Paris"
 - d. "Quittin' Your"
4. What is the reviewer's overall rating of the CD?
 - a. one star out of five
 - b. two stars out of five
 - c. three stars out of five
 - d. five stars out of five

Reading for SylvanSync™

Grades 9–12

Music Review

Part 3

Use the following two-column chart to note claims in one column and supporting details or evidence in the other. If there are no supporting details to support a claim, write “none” in the column. Then answer the question that follows.

Claims	Supporting Details

1. Does the reviewer adequately support claims in the review? Explain. Write your response on your writing paper.

Part 4

Answer the following questions on your writing paper.

1. Does the reviewer reveal too much or too little about the CD? Support your answer with specific details.
2. What is the reviewer's tone or voice in the review?
3. How does the reviewer establish his or her authority to write this review?
4. What details did the reviewer not include that are typically found in a music review?
5. What additional questions do you have about the music?

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Music Review

Part 5

Write an authoritative music review of a concert or CD on your writing paper. Make sure that your review includes the elements of a music review and support your claims and opinion. Your writing will be evaluated using the following 3-point rubric.

Writing Rubric

Score	Addresses the Topic	Supports the Topic Appropriately	Uses Correct Grammar, Capitalization, Punctuation, and Spelling
3	Targets the writing exactly to the topic. Does not shift focus.	Uses several appropriate characteristics of the genre to support the main topic.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout the writing.
2	Does a good job staying on topic. May wander or shift focus slightly.	Uses a few characteristics of the genre to support the main topic.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout some of the writing.
1	Does not address the topic at all.	Does not use appropriate characteristics of the genre to support the topic.	There is no attempt at correct capitalization, punctuation, and spelling in the writing.

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Cultural Literature Analysis

Objectives

The student will be able to:

- compare and contrast the styles, themes, and cultural references of two similar folktales from different cultures.
- write a version of a folktale, using your own cultural references.

Materials

- writing paper

Background Information

Critical reading includes making **comparisons** and **contrasts**. Comparisons show similarities between people, objects, and events. Contrasts show the differences. When comparing and contrasting different pieces of literature you might analyze the styles, the themes, the author's viewpoint based on various aspects of culture and historical references.

One common literary form that you probably had read to you as child is a folktale. A folktale is a story or legend that has been passed down from one generation to the next and eventually becomes part of the culture of the people. Folktales were initially told orally and were used to explain the world. The stories usually took place long ago and include talking animals, mythical creatures, kings, and peasants. There is a common theme that mirrors the values and culture of the people who originated the story.

Many folktales have a central idea about life or **theme**. Because the writer usually doesn't state the theme directly, you will have to discover it on your own.

These steps can help you determine the theme.

- First, think about the title. It may provide a clue to the characters and a problem that they need to solve.
- Second, think about the characters. Think about their actions, thoughts, and feelings. What do the characters talk about with each other? What is their main problem? What do they learn from solving the problem?
- Third, think about the passage's events and setting.
- Finally, look for an idea that is repeated throughout the passage.

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Activity

Complete the activities that follow on a separate sheet of paper.

Part 1

On your paper, write the type of story that you might read that would have the following themes.

1. Crime does not pay.
2. Persistence and hard work will pay off in the end.
3. You should always stand up for what you believe is right.
4. Patience and kindness are important.
5. Do what you say you are going to do.

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Part 2

Read the Portuguese folktale “The Two Children and the Witch” and the Russian folktale “Baba Yaga.”

The Two Children and the Witch

There was once a woman who had a son and a daughter. The mother one day sent her son to buy five cents worth of beans, and then said to both: “My children, go as far out on the road as you shall find shells of beans strewed on the path, and when you reach the wood you will find me there collecting fire-wood.” The children did as they were bid; and after the mother had gone out they went following the track of the beans, but they did not find her. As night had come on they perceived in the darkness a light shining at a distance. They walked on toward it, and they soon came up to an old woman who was frying cakes. The old woman was blind of one eye, and the boy went on the blind side and stole a cake, because he felt so hungry. Believing that it was her cat which had stolen the cake, she said, “You thief of a cat! Leave my cakes alone; they are not meant for you!” The little boy now said to his sister, “You go now and take a cake.” But the little girl replied, “I cannot do so, as I am sure to laugh.” Still, as the boy persisted upon it and urged her to try, she had no other alternative but to do so. She went on the side of the old woman's blind eye and stole another of her cakes. The old woman, again thinking that it was her cat, said, “Be off! Shoo! These cakes are not meant for you!”

The little girl now burst out into a fit of laughter, and the old hag turning round then, noticed the two children, and addressed them thus: “Ah! Is it you, my dear grandchildren? Eat, eat away, and get fat!” She then took hold of them and thrust them into a large box full of chestnuts, and shut them up. Next day she came close to the box and spoke to them thus: “Show me your little fingers, my pets, that I may be able to judge whether you have grown fat.” The children put out their little fingers as desired. But next day the old hag again asked them: “Show your little fingers, my little dears, that I may see if you have grown fat and plump!” The children, instead of their little fingers, showed her the tail of a cat they had found inside the box. The old hag then said: “My pets, you can come out now, for you have grown nice and plump.”

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She took them out of the box, and told them they must go with her and gather sticks. The children went into the wood searching one way while the old hag took another path. When they had arrived at a certain spot they met a fairy. This fairy said to them: "You are gathering sticks, my children, to heat the oven, but you do not know that the old hag wants to bake you in it." She further told them that the old witch meant to order them to stand on the baker's tray, saying: "Stand on this tray, my little pets, that I may see you dance in the oven;" but that they were to ask her to sit upon it herself first, that so they might learn the way to do it. The fairy then went away.

Shortly after they found the old witch in the wood. They carried all the fire-sticks home to heat the oven. When they had finished heating the oven, the old hag swept it carefully out, and then said to the little ones, "Sit here, my little darlings, on this tray, that I may see how prettily you dance in the oven!" The children replied to the witch as the good fairy had instructed them: "Sit you here, little granny that we may first see you dance in the oven." As the hag's intention was to bake the children, she sat on the tray first, so as to coax them to do the same after her; but the very moment the children saw her on the tray they thrust the tray into the oven with the witch upon it. The old hag gave a great start, and was burnt to a cinder immediately. The children took possession of the shed and all it contained.

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Baba Yaga

Somewhere in vast Russia, there lived a peasant with his wife and they had a son and daughter. One day the wife died and the husband mourned for a long time. One year passed, and two years, and even longer. A day came when the man thought, "If I marry again possibly it would turn out all right." And so he did, and had children by his second wife.

The stepmother was envious of the stepson and daughter and began to treat them harshly. She scolded them without any reason, sent them away from home as often as she wished, and gave them scarcely enough to eat. Finally she wanted to get rid of them. A wicked feeling was growing in the stepmother's heart, and she determined to send the children to the witch, thinking sure enough that they would never return.

"Dear children," she said to the orphans, "go to my grandmother, Baba Yaga, who lives in the forest in a hut. You will do everything she wants you to, and she will give you sweet things to eat and you will be happy."

The orphans started out. But instead of going to the witch, the sister, a bright little girl, took her brother by the hand and ran to their grandmother and told her all about their going to the forest.

"Oh, my poor darlings!" said the good grandmother, pitying the children. "You are being sent to a wicked witch. Now listen to me, my darlings. I will give you a hint: Be kind and good to everyone; do not speak ill words to any one; do not despise helping the weakest, and always hope that for you, too, there will be the needed help." The good old grandmother gave the children milk to drink and to each a big slice of ham. She also gave them some cookies and when the children departed she stood looking after them a long, long time.

The obedient children arrived at the forest and there stood the hut of Baba Yaga. The children were afraid, and stood very close together, but in spite of their fear they said very politely: "Ho, grandmother, our stepmother sent us to thee to serve thee."

"All right; I am not opposed to keeping you, children. If you satisfy all my wishes I shall reward you; if not, I shall eat you up." Without any delay the witch ordered the girl to spin the thread, and the boy to carry water in a sieve to fill a big tub. The poor orphan girl wept at her spinning-wheel and wiped away her bitter tears. At once all around her appeared small mice

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squeaking and saying: "Sweet girl, do not cry. Give us cookies and we will help thee." The little girl willingly did so. "Now," gratefully squeaked the mice, "go and find the black cat. He is very hungry; give him a slice of ham and he will help thee."

The girl speedily went in search of the cat and saw her brother in great distress about the tub, so many times he had filled the sieve, yet the tub was still dry. The little birds passed, flying nearby, and chirped: "Kind-hearted little children, give us some crumbs and we will advise you." The orphans gave the birds some crumbs and the grateful birds chirped again: "Some clay and water, children dear!" Then away they flew through the air.

The children understood, spat in the sieve, plastered it with clay and filled the tub in a very short time. Then they both returned to the hut and met the black cat. They gave him some of the good ham which their good grandmother had given them, petted him and asked: "Dear Kitty-cat, black and pretty, tell us what to do in order to get away from the witch?"

"Well," answered the cat, "I will give you a towel and a comb and then you must run away. When you hear the witch running after you, drop the towel and a large river will appear in place of the towel. If you hear her once more, throw down the comb and in place of the comb there will appear a dark wood. This will protect you from the wicked witch."

Baba Yaga came home just then. "Is it not wonderful?" she thought; "everything is exactly right." "Well," she said to the children, "today you were brave and smart; let us see tomorrow. Your work will be more difficult, and I hope I shall eat you up."

The poor orphans went to bed on the straw in a cold corner. Nearly scared to death from fear, they lay there, afraid to talk, afraid even to breathe. The next morning the witch ordered all the linen to be woven and a large supply of firewood to be brought from the forest.

The children took the towel and comb and ran as fast as their feet could carry them. The dogs were after them, but they threw them the cookies that were left; the gates did not open, but the children smoothed them with oil; the birch trees almost scratched their eyes out, but the gentle girl fastened a pretty ribbon to it. So they went farther and farther and ran out of the dark forest into the wide, sunny fields.

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The cat sat down by the loom and tore the thread to pieces, doing it with delight. Baba Yaga returned. "Where are the children?" she shouted, and began to beat the cat. "Why hast thou let them go?"

The cat answered: "Well, it was because I have served thee so many years and thou hast never given me a bite, while the dear children gave me some good ham."

Baba Yaga understood that there was no help and started to follow the children. In her great hurry she forgot to look for the towel and the comb, but jumped astride a broom. The children heard her coming and threw the towel down. At once a river appeared and watered the field. Baba Yaga hopped along the shore until she finally found a shallow place and crossed it.

Again the children heard her so they threw down the comb. This time a thick forest appeared. The witch tried very hard to pass through, but in vain, and very angry, she returned home.

The orphans rushed to their father, told him their pitiful story: "Ah, father dear, why dost thou love us less than our new brothers and sisters?"

The father was touched and became angry. He sent the wicked stepmother away and lived a new life with his good children. From that time he watched over their happiness and never neglected them anymore.

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Now answer these questions.

1. What is the theme of these two folktales?
2. Compare and contrast how these two folktales develop the theme.
3. Compare and contrast the style of the two folktales.
4. Compare and contrast the cultural references of the two folktales.
5. Which folktale do you like better and why?
6. Which folktale in your culture is similar to these two folktales?

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Cultural Literature Analysis

Part 3

Write a version of a folktale, using your own cultural references. Your writing will be evaluated using the following 3-point rubric. Write your piece on your paper.

Writing Rubric

Score	Addresses the Structure of a Folktale	Develops the Folktale Based on Appropriate Cultural References	Uses Correct Grammar, Capitalization, Punctuation, and Spelling
3	Targets the structure of a folktale exactly.	Develops the folktale based on appropriate cultural references.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout the folktale.
2	Does a good job of targeting the structure of the folktale but wanders a bit.	Partially develops the folktale based on appropriate cultural references.	Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling are used correctly throughout some of the folktale.
1	Does not address the structure of the folktale at all.	Does not develop the folktale based on appropriate cultural references.	There is no attempt at correct capitalization, punctuation, and spelling in the folktale.